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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL





PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' answering to the queries raised by parliamentarians in the House of Representatives in Kathmandu on Sunday.

PM expresses firm resolve to ensure corruption control

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has reiterated his commitment to good governance and corruption control.

Speaking during the question-and-answer session in the House of Representatives on Sunday, he asserted his fearlessness stating that he was not afraid of losing his position.

Responding to concerns raised by MPs about the slow progress in corruption investigations involving influential figures, the Prime Minister affirmed that investigations have commenced, dismissing any fears of government failure while reiterating his determination to maintain a corruption-free administration. "Had I been afraid of losing my chair, the investigation in fake Bhutanese refugee case could not have begun," he said.

Responding to a question from MP Kalpana Chaudhary regarding legal arrangements for implementing the rights outlined in the Constitution, the Prime Minister revealed that a National Education Bill, incorporating reservations for the Tharu community, has been submitted.

Additionally, he pledged the swift introduction of the Federal Civil Service Bill, ensuring reservations for Tharus in the civil service, aligning with the Supreme Court's mandate and upholding fundamental rights. In response to the issue of Chure destruction raised by MP Kiran Kumar Shah, the Prime Minister assured the government's commitment to protecting the region's biodiversity and natural resources. "Ongoing efforts include river control and embankment projects to counter river erosion in the Chure area.

The President Chure Tarai Madhes Conservation Development Committee is actively involved in annual conservation programmes, and plans for revising the Chure Conservation Master Plan aim to enhance the effectiveness of the national conservation initiative," said PM Prachanda.

He affirmed the government's commitment to addressing economic pressures through macroeconomic stability, emphasising the promotion of domestic production and job creation. A national campaign, the Internal Employment Promotion Decade, is underway to enhance local skill development and boost investment in productive sectors, with a focus on indigenous labour.

In response to MP Dr. K. R. Rai's concerns about climate change and biodiversity conservation, Prime Minister Prachanda highlighted Nepal's active role in the international arena in addressing the impact of climate change. Emphasising the responsibility of developed nations in carbon emissions, the government has advocated for equitable resources and technology transfer to underdeveloped countries. United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres has acknowledged the challenges faced by Nepal, creating a foundation to press for compensation to support green development.

"To address climate change impacts, the government is implementing the National Adaptation Plan 2021-2050 and the Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC Implementation Plan) under the Paris Agreement. The Sixteenth Plan will specifically focus on climate change and biodiversity conservation.

In the upcoming annual budget, ministries and government agencies will be directed to formulate climate-friendly plans," said PM Prachanda.

Furthermore, PM Prachanda informed that the government was actively involved in wildlife conservation through 20 protected areas, with special priority programmes planned for the coming financial year.

Responding to MP Krishna Gopal Shrestha's inquiries, Prime Minister Prachanda provided insights into the government's plans regarding rural migration and the suggestions received

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DEMOCRACY DAY MESSAGES

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 19

President Ramchandra Paudel and Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav have extended their best wishes to all Nepali people on the occasion of National Democracy Day 2080 by issuing separate statements on Monday.

"Paying tribute to all the known and unknown martyrs who sacrificed their precious lives in various struggles for the establishment of democracy, I express my respect and reverence to the elders who led the movement for the establishment of democracy in the country," President Paudel said in his message.

I wish that Democracy Day will help in achieving the national goals of sustainable peace, good governance, development and prosperity while showing respect to all those who have contributed to the various movements for Nepal's sovereignty, territorial integrity, national interest, self-respect and democracy, he added.

Nepal celebrates Democracy Day on Falgun 7 of Nepali calendar every year as a way of remembering and honouring the historical achievement made in human rights and political freedom as a result of the successful revolution of 2007 BS (February 19, 1951) and the sacrificial struggle against the autocracy.

President also said that this day is marked as a proud and unforgettable day in the history of Nepal because the belief that the sovereignty of the country should be vested in people was established on this day through the struggle and sacrifice of martyrs. "We must not forget that the revolution of 2007 BS was an important foundation for the establishment of the federal democratic republic achieved through long struggle and sacrifice and the creation of the current constitution made by the people themselves," said President Poudel.

He also added that the Federal Democratic Republic is an important achievement made by us Nepalis after a long struggle of more than seven decades. Democracy further strengthens the overall national unity including social justice, equality, social harmony and prosperity.

The President said in the message that the democracy has established the belief that the people are the entire source of state power. The Constitution of Nepal aims to build a socialist-oriented economy based on justice and equality by adopting a federal democratic republican system.

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Democracy Day Special Supplement

Today's TRN carries a special supplement to mark 74th National Democracy Day



Term of dedicated feeder and trunk lines probe panel extended

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

The government has extended the term of the inquiry committee formed to settle the dispute related to the electricity tariff of customers of the dedicated feeders and trunk lines by one month.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held at the Office of Prime Minister and Council of Ministers on Sunday decided this.

The government had formed a three-member committee headed by former Supreme Court justice Girish Chandra Lal on January 9.

According to Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma, the Cabinet meeting has also decided to form a working group under the coordination of the secretary of the Ministry of Home Affairs to study and submit the modified draft within two months after studying the procedure for determining and reviewing the percentage of disabled persons injured in the armed conflict.

> The government has sacked executive director Bikal Poudel of the Security Printing Centre, Panauti, Kavre.

The government has sacked executive director Bikal Poudel of the Security Printing Centre, Panauti, Kavre, after it was found that he has obtained a US legal permanent resident permit.

Similarly, the Cabinet meeting has approved the National Broadcasting 12th Amendment Rules, 2080.

The government has allowed tabling of a bill to amend the Banks and Financial Institutions Act, 2073 in the Federal Parliament. Further, the government has approved the Probation and Parole Policy, 2080.

The Cabinet meeting has appointed Dr. Chandika Prasad Bhatta as executive director of Nepal Oil Corporation, Bhupendra Bhandari as the Chairman of Nepal Telecommunication Authority and Dr. Pramod Joshi as member secretary of Nepal Health Research Council.

Minister Sharma said that the Cabinet meeting decided to send the report of the committee formed to study and investigate the sale and purchase of shares of Ncell to the relevant authorities for implementation.

'Federal democracy has no alternative'

The nation is marking the 74th National Democracy Day today. The celebration is being made amid negative propaganda about the federal democratic republican system the nation has adopted. In this regard, Minister for Communication and Information Technology and government spokesperson **Rekha Sharma** spoke to Consulting Editor of Gorkhapatra Corporation **Upesh Maharjan, Purushottam Khatri** of *The Rising Nepal* and **Birendra Oli** of *Gorkhapatra* at her official residence on the eve of Democracy Day on Sunday. Excerpts:

■ How do you assess the one-year term of the government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'?

The government has already reviewed its one-year term led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on December 26, 2023. The government has done a serious self-review of the works done by the government and has set the future priority of the government. The main focus of the government is governance, social justice and economic prosperity. Keeping these three agendas at the centre, the government has been moving ahead firmly.

Although some forces are working to depict the present federal democratic system as a failure, the alternative to the federal democratic system is the reformed federal democratic system only. The government within the last year has successfully cleared the false narratives and institutionalising the achievement gained through the political movements.

In a government that operates by the rule of law, no one is allowed to breach the law. Everyone should adhere to the constitution and rule of law. The government has become successful in establishing the notion that a person breaching the law will face legal consequences. Fame, designation and political nexus do not count before the rule of law.

The government has been moving ahead to clear the frustration of the public addressing the issue of citizenship, and loan sharks by forming a commission. Within a year, very important dynamics have been established in the sector of good governance, social justice and the road to achieving economic prosperity.

■ Although the government has succeeded in instilling hope in the public, in which areas do you think that the government has not been able to work satisfactorily?

There are certainly some works and programmes which cannot be accomplished in a year, but such programmes would be implemented gradually. We have been able to instill hope in the public. We believe that the government has no right to commit mistakes.

It would be wrong to think that this government has failed when the Prime Minister himself made self evaluation and said that he could not do as much as he wanted. It should be understood in a way that the present government has wished to do more.

Please scan the QR code for related video

■ From the Bhutanese refugee, Lalita Niwas land grab case, and gold scam to the Bansbari Shoe Factory scandal, the government is trying to send a message that is action-oriented on corruption control, but it seems that it has not been completely successful. What are the reasons for this?

As per the principle of separation of power government is the executive body and there are legislative and judiciary which are equally important.

And these two bodies are independent to function from their sides. The government has not just arrested the low-profile public but has been able to arrest some high-profile figures which is an achievement in itself. The government has also booked many high-profile political leaders in the fake Bhutanese refugees scam, gold smuggling, Lalita Niwas land scam and other cases. Based on available facts and proof, the government is ready to bring anybody to legal action. The verdict given by the court is final in these cases but the government has set an example in breaking VIP culture by arresting high-profile people attached to the case and taking legal action against them.



PHOTO: KESHAB GURUNG

Minister Rekha Sharma

» INTERVIEW

■ What pressures did the government face while controlling corruption and establishing good governance?

People in favour of good governance, and transparency have supported the good endeavours of the government. The government has surpassed unwanted pressure and has been just, and unbiased while delivering services. It is also true that the government while taking action against anybody, should not be guided by any prejudice.

■ How do you address people's discontent that the system has changed but the situation of the public has not improved comparatively?

We have become able to alter the political system by the sacrifice of many lives, but in reality, the livelihood of many grassroots public has not changed as expected. If we become able to revive the sick industries we will be able to create more jobs we will become more or less self-reliant. The equitable distribution of change and achievement should reach people and communities of all backgrounds while working in the sector of social justice. Equitable distribution of resources can bring positive change in the lives of people when three-tier governments work in a coordinated way.

■ Periodic elections and democracy are synonymous with each other, but there are increasing complaints that the election has become expensive, how can this be addressed?

Whatever the present electoral system we have adopted, it has already been arranged in our constitution. The present leadership of the government alone cannot amend this electoral arrangement instantly.

But, What I think is that this issue can be settled by maintaining a common understanding among the political parties.

However, we political parties are responsible for making the election extravagant and expensive. To win the election one should have strong agendas that appeal the public and the recent elections have established the fact that one cannot win the election by spending beyond the EC's code of conduct.

Our party during the 2008 election was able to win two-thirds without doing much hullaballoo. Making the electoral system less expensive is the long-term planning and agenda of all the political parties.

■ On the eve of the Democracy Day today, we have been encountering various criticism regarding the present political system, and on the other side, we have been facing challenges to implement the federal democratic system. How analyse these challenges?

I think it depends upon two things, regarding the implementation of the federal democratic system, there has been planted and vested interest being made to alter this system. As a result, today, we have been hearing negative propaganda on this system from some dogmatic and reactionary forces.

We also have some limitations and problems within us, taking advantage of our parties' problems and limitations, some forces are staging various movements at present keeping their vested interest in creating negativity towards this political achievement.

The foundation of our political system lies in the achievement of the 1950s movement. As we are marking the 74th Democracy Day we have to commemorate the sacrifice of our freedom fighters. All political changes and the nation being a federal democratic republic has been based on the foundation 1950s movement to establish democracy.

■ Chief Ministers from the provinces are complaining that they could not work because the federal government did not give necessary laws, when can this problem be addressed?

As I have already mentioned the two Acts are mainly important for now, and they are the Federal Civil Service Act and Police Adjustment Act, which we had already tabled in the previous session of the parliament but could not pass them.

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BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 117,600
Worked Gold	: Rs. 117,050
Silver	: Rs. 1,430

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,034.82
Total Amount	: 3,775,422,196.17
No. of Share	: 10,772,483

ANTI-MONEY LAUNDERING BILL SENT TO LEGISLATION COMMITTEE

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

The meeting of the National Assembly on Sunday sent the Bill designed to amend some Acts related to the prevention of money laundering and promotion of business environment-- 2079 BS to the relevant committee for clause-wise discussion.

The proposal by Minister of Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung that the bill be sent to the Legislation Management Committee for clause-wise discussion was unanimously approved by the Upper House.

Similarly, Chairperson of the Delegated Management and Government Assurance Committee Maya Prasad Sharma submitted the annual report of the Committee for the year 2079-80 in the meeting.

Chairperson of the National Concern and Coordination Committee Dil Kumari Rawal Thapa (Parbati), tabled the study report on tier-wise inter-relationship and coordination of the Committee.

Simkot going through 14-hour daily power cuts



PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

NEA office, Humla

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla Feb. 18

Hildum Power Distribution Centre has increased the load shedding time to 14 hours a day. The daily load-shedding hours have been increased after decreasing electricity generation due to reduced water level in the river.

Shankar Prasad Hamal, chief of the distribution centre, said that due to the lack of water resources, the load shedding schedule was increased to 14 hours a day after the power generation decreased. The centre, which has been supplying electricity to two rural municipalities -- Simkot and Kharpunath Rural Municipality, has been cutting power for 12 to 14 hours a day.

A few days ago, the daily load shedding schedule was increased from four to eight hours a day. Hamal said that the source of water required for the power house has decreased due to the lack of rain fall which affected the production and compelled a power outage.

A power house with a power generation capacity of 500 kilowatts currently produces between 100 to 20 kilowatts in peak and normal hours. Currently, there is a demand of more than one megawatt of electricity in Simkot. A businessman of Simkot market Saroj Rawat said that consumers have been hit after the Centre cut power supply for up to 14 hours a day.

He said that the business of electronic materials has also decreased and there is also a problem in lighting the households. Due to the increase in load shedding, the furniture industries have closed and the consumers have stopped using electronic equipment.

The consumption of firewood has increased after the electricity supply has been cut in the morning and evening, said locals. More than 3,000 households have been affected from the power outage in these rural municipalities.

POLICY SOUGHT ON HOME-BASED WORKERS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Under the five-day World Social Forum (WSF) 2024 that started in Bhritkutimadap, Kathmandu from Thursday, stakeholders have emphasised on management of the home-based workers and formulate a policy.

In a programme titled 'The Challenges and Victories of Home-Based Workers in South Asia' organised by Centre for Labour and Social Studies (CLASS) Nepal, the participants demanded to identify Home Based Workers (HBW) and manage the market to sell their produce.

They said that the unseen and unheard plight of HBWs has not been addressed despite their being a significant part of labour force and an immense contribution to the global economy.

Goma Pandey, Secretary of CLASS Nepal, said that HBWs have been generating income through skilled works such as sewing, weaving, and embroidery. The government should help them manage the market to sell the products they make.

Srishti Joshi, Regional Coordinator of HomeNet South Asia, called for mechanisms to transform HBWs status to be an equal citizen with economic prosperity and better well-being.

The International Labour Organisation (ILO) Convention 177 has explained the rights of Home-Based Workers. The orgaisation works for HBWs and advocated for ratification process of ILO Convention 177, said Bandana Aryal, National Project Coordinator, and ILO Nepal.

Pakistani home worker Uma Laila Azhar, Executive Director of HomeNet Pakistan, said that the situation of the domestic workers in Pakistan remains critical as the government has not yet ratified ILO Convention 177 and the state has not formulated any policy in this regard.

According to the Nepal Labour Survey Force Survey-Report 2017/18 of the Central Bureau of Statistics, 19.2 per cent of the Nepalis are active HBWs and more than 70 per cent of them are women.

Bardibas Food Festival offers varieties of cuisines

RSS
Mahottari, Feb. 18

The hotel and tourism entrepreneurs of Mahottari have joined hands and organized a street food festival here with the objective of publicizing their place and increasing public interest on local cuisine.

Bardibas Municipality Mayor Pralhad Kumar Chhetri inaugurated the three-day event organized by the Hotel and Tourism Entrepreneurs Association, Mahottari here on Saturday. The street food festival is organized at the meeting point of the East-West Highway and the BP Highway, 500 metres towards the BP Highway. The Festival will run till tomorrow.

The Association stated that the Festival aims to cater a variety of food items at a single place. It believed that the event will help publicize Bardibas and increase interest in the local indigenous food varieties.

Stalls offering a variety of food items as sidra, ghongi, smoked fish, neetle soup, timbur, gundruk, tama, beans, jilebi prepared from chhena, sweets and cookies, Newari snack package and popular international cuisines have been kept in the Festival.

Apart from hotel and restaurant entrepreneurs, the hotel management and dairy students of the Nirmal Lama Polytechnic School, Khayarmara, Bardibas-11, Nepal Academy of Tourism and Hotel Management (NATHM), Bardibas and the Secondary School Bardibas-8, Hathilet have also run their stalls.

There are 50 stalls preparing separate food varieties in the Festival and the visitors can observe and enjoy the taste of a range of food items. Association's general secretary Narayan Ghimire said domestic and external tourists can satisfy their taste buds with local cuisines amidst the hospitality with a distinct identity of Madhesh.

A discount of 20 to 40 percent has been offered on the food. The Festival also features various cultural programmes.

The organizers expect that about 50 thousand people will visit the Festival which has been organized at a cost of around Rs 1.5 million.

This street food festival is also expected to contribute to the cause of a trekking campaign initiated few days back by the Association and the Bardibas Town Journalists Network, Mahottari, which aims to explore and publicize the tourism destinations and possibilities in Bardibas.

COLD STORAGE CONSTRUCTED IN WEST NAWALPARASI

RSS
Nawalparasi, Feb. 18

Farmers in west Nawalparasi have been elated with the construction of a cold storage facility in their area for the first time.

The facility with a capacity of 3,000 metric tonnes is constructed at Sunawal at an investment of Rs 210 million. It was built under the leadership of the District Cooperatives Association and with financial contribution of the federal government, local government and the various cooperatives based in the district.

The three-storied facility with separate chambers has been constructed and is in the final stages of operation after preparing the operation guidelines, it is stated. Local farmers are attracted towards the facility and they are also motivated to take to commercial farming now, said Loknath Bhadari of Sunawal-2.

"Now we have the cold storage facility in our locality to store surplus agriculture produce. I am happy," he added. Like Bhandari, many farmers are excited with the operation of the cold storage from this year.

Even the agriculture cooperatives have started growing crops, fruits and vegetables in large area of land.

"It is not possible to build such facility in every market. Therefore, this cold storage facility at Sunawal should be developed into a common storage centre of all farmers," said Bishnu Poudel, the president of the District Cooperatives Association.

Trump hawks $399 branded shoes



AP
Philadelphia, Feb. 18

As he closes in on the Republican presidential nomination, former President Donald Trump made a highly unusual stop Saturday, hawking new Trump-branded sneakers at "Sneaker Con," a gathering that bills itself as the "The Greatest Sneaker Show on Earth."

Trump was met with loud boos as well as cheers at the Philadelphia Convention Center as he introduced what he called the first official Trump footwear.

The shoes, shiny gold high tops with an American flag detail on the back, are being sold as "Never Surrender High-Tops" for $399 on a new website that also sells other Trump-branded shoes and "Victory47" cologne and perfume for $99 a bottle. He'd be the 47th president if elected again.

The website says it has no connection to Trump's campaign, though Trump campaign officials promoted the appearance in online posts.

The unannounced launch came a day after a judge in New York ordered Trump and his company to pay a whopping $355 million in penalties, finding that the former president lied about his wealth for years, scheming to dupe banks, insurers and others by inflating his wealth on financial statements.

That penalty came after Trump was ordered to pay an additional $83.3 million to the writer E. Jean Carroll for damaging her reputation after she accused him of sexual assault. With interest payments, Trump's legal debts might now exceed a half-billion dollars — an amount it is unclear he can afford to pay.

Trump's appearance was met with clashing boos from his detractors and chants of "USA!" from supporters who arrived at the sneaker event decked out in Trump gear. The dueling chants made it difficult, at times, to hear Trump speak. Some had been given signs that read "SNEAKERHEADS LOVE TRUMP."

"There's a lot of emotion in this room," Trump said of the reaction, after holding up and showing off a pair of gold shoes, then placing one on each side of his podium.

"This is something that I've been talking about for 12 years, 13 years. And I think it's going to be a big success," he said. As he spoke, the smell of weed occasionally wafted through the room.

Some of those who attended said they were unaware Trump would be there, and continued to shop as a crowd gathered around the stage. Many in the audience said they were not from the city and instead hailed from nearby states and Washington, D.C.

The attendees skewed younger and more diverse than Trump's usual rally crowds. Trump's campaign is hoping he will be able to win over more young and minority voters, particularly young Black men, in a likely rematch against President Joe Biden in November.

This isn't the first money-making venture Trump has announced since launching his third campaign for the White House in 2022. Trump last year reported making between $100,000 and $1 million from a series of digital trading cards that portrayed him, through photo editing, in a series of cartoon-like images, including as an astronaut, a cowboy and a superhero. He has also released books featuring photos of his time in office and letters written to him through the years.

Before he ran for office, Trump hawked everything from steaks to vodka to a venture he called "Trump University." The new sneaker website says it is run by CIC Ventures LLC, a company that Trump reported owning in his 2023 financial disclosure. The website states the new venture "is not political and has nothing to do with any political campaign."

Still, it describes the sneakers as a limited-edition, numbered "true collector's item" that is "Bold, gold, and tough, just like President Trump."

"The Never Surrender sneakers are your rally cry in shoe form," the description reads. "Lace-up and step out ready to conquer."

Chamber stresses measures for investment environment

Nepal Chamber of Commerce

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

President of Nepal Chamber of Commerce Rajendra Malla has said that the main challenge for the economy was the inability to create an investment environment in the country.

While addressing the annual general meeting of National Trade Association on Sunday, Malla said that even though there was adequate availability of investable funds in the market, the inability to invest and the inability to flourish business is an obstacle to economic prosperity.

"Nearly Rs. 500 billion of investable funds have accumulated in banks and financial institutions, but the government has not been able to spend the capital budget. Even with more liquidity, the investment environment has not been created," he said. According to him, investment has not been attracted due to high interest rates in banks and financial institutions.

Although there are some signs of improvement in the external indicators of the economy, there has been no improvement in the domestic environment, he said and emphasised that the economic and financial policy should be reviewed to make the economy viable.

He said that the country' economy would be vibrant if the capital budget was spent as targeted. Malla said that a time schedule should be determined so that the expenditure is done on time.

He said, "Even after seven months of the current fiscal year, the development expenditure is limited to 21 per cent. The practice of bringing ambitious budget in the beginning and making amendments after not being able to spend it in time should be ended."

President Malla emphasised that Nepal Rastra Bank should introduce a monetary policy to extend loans to small and medium enterprises.

"Due to the lack of domestic production, the trade deficit has reached Rs. 693 billion in the current fiscal year. In order to reduce the country's existing trade deficit, it is necessary to adopt fiscal and monetary policies that expand investment in agriculture, energy, tourism and information technology, he said.

Minorities protest Kosovo over Serbian dinar

AP
Mitrovica, Kosovo Feb. 18

Thousands of minority Serbs in Kosovo on Monday protested a ban of the use of the Serbian currenc y in areas where they live, an issue that has been the cause of the latest crisis in relations between Serbia and Kosovo.

Tensions escalated after the government of Kosovo, a former Serbian province, banned banks and other financial institutions in the Serb-populated areas from using the dinar in local transactions, starting Feb. 1, and imposed the euro.

The dinar was widely used in ethnic Serbian-dominated areas, especially in Kosovo's north, to pay pensions and salaries to staff in Serbian-run institutions, including schools and hospitals.

The ban has angered both Kosovo Serbs and Serbia. The leaders of Serbia and Kosovo sparred over the issue at a meeting last week at the United Nations Security Council.

Protesters at the rally in the Serb part of the divided northern Kosovo town of Mitrovica said that abolishing the dinar violates the rights of the Serbs in Kosovo and is discriminatory. They urged the international community to put pressure on the Kosovo government to reverse the move.

"This virtually means taking away food from our tables," said Dusanka Djorovic, from a local pensioners' association. Dragisa Milovic, a doctor, said that Kosovo's decision "is aimed at abolishing Serb institutions in these areas."

In Pristina, Kosovo's Prime Minister Albin Kurti dismissed such criticism in a message to the Kosovo Serbs. Kurti insisted that the new measure is aimed



at curbing illegal money flow and "does not stop Serbia from financially assisting the citizens of Kosovo's Serb community."

"Kosovo did not stop the dinar, or the dollar, pound, or Swiss franc," said Kurti. "The only change from Feb. 1 is that the cash cannot cross the border in sacks ... but should come through bank accounts and (be) withdrawn in euros."

In 1999, a 78-day NATO bombing campaign ended a war between Serbian government forces and ethnic Albanian separatists in Kosovo. Serbian forces were pushed out but Belgrade never recognized Kosovo's independence and still considers it a Serbian province.

The European Union and the United States have expressed concern that Kosovo's ban of the dinar could raise tensions in an already volatile region and called for consultations and a delay in the ban.

The EU has brokered negotiations between Serbia and Kosovo in a bid to normalize their relations but the talks have showed slow progress while occasional violent incidents have fuelled fears of instability in the Balkans as the war rages in Ukraine.

President Paudel observes Madhavnarayan Mela

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

President Ramchandra Paudel visited Shalinadi in Shankharapur Municipality on Sunday morning and participated in the Madhavanarayan Mela as part of the Shree Swasthani Brata Katha.

On the occasion, President Paudel paid obeisance and worshipped Shri Swasthani and Madhavnarayan. He also performed worship at the Bajrayogini Temple.

Speaking in brief on the occasion, President Paudel said that it was a matter of happiness for him to visit the Bajrayogini Temple which carries ancient, historical, cultural and touristic importance.

He expressed the belief that the state would give special attention to the development of Bajrayogini and Shalinadi areas, which, he said, have historical importance from the time of princess Bhrikuti and Songtsen Gampo.

Sobita Gautam, Member of Parliament elected from Kathmandu Constituency No. 2, who invited the President to visit Shalinadi, expressed her belief that the visit of the President would draw the attention of the government on the further preservation and management of Shalinadi.



PHOTO: RSS

President Ramchandra Paudel participates Madhavanarayan Mela as a part of the Shree Swasthani Brata Katha at Shalinadi on Sunday morning.

"Although the Shalinadi and Madhavanarayan temples are important from mythological and religious point of view, they have been neglected," she said. Likewise, people's representatives including MPs and the mayor and deputy mayor of the municipality complained that despite being an area of religious, cultural and historical importance, reconstruction work of Shalinadi area has not picked up speed while some development works remain incomplete.

Around 300,000 devotees visit Shalinadi fair every year.

NRNA regrets its decision to buy Lalita Niwas land for its global secretariate

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

The Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA) has expressed regrets over the confusion and controversy on its decision to invest in buying land at the Lalita Niwas and constructing its global secretariat there.

"We regret that such a big and sensitive investment decision of the NRNA could not be free from confusion and controversy. The association is committed to resolving the confusion and inconvenience caused to all donors and members," it said in a statement on Sunday.

The NRNA had spent about Rs. 290 million in purchasing the land, existing buildings and construction of the secretariat.

The funds were the social investment from all the members, well-wishers, national coordinating councils and central officials from all over the world.

The NRNA had purchased 3 ropanis (48 aanas) of land about eight years ago at the rate of Rs. 2.65 million per aana along with a building from Shovakanta Dhakal, Ramkumar Subedi, Sandip Dhakal, Uma Kumari Dhakal and Madhavi Subedi.

It informed that the payment was made in a cheque via bank.

In its recent decision, the Special Court had given its verdict to nationalise about 284 ropanis of land including the NRNA's office building in Lalita Niwas. Since the NRNA purchased the land as per the Cabinet decision and got a discount in land registration, we were clear about the legality of the land, it said while expressing sorrow at the news that the land had been confiscated.

Likewise, the Association said that it would appeal against the decision of the Special Court and its effect to the Supreme Court for final resolution.

Until the Supreme Court issues its verdict, the right of use and ownership of the land shall remain with the NRNA, it claimed.

"During the construction of the current central secretariat building built with the Association's investment, approval was obtained from the Kathmandu Metropolitan City and the construction of the building was completed by the decision of the Supreme Court," it said.

According to the NRNA, if the Supreme Court decides otherwise, it has the right to file a case in District Court Kathmandu against the sellers of the land to claim compensation.

Conference recommends reforms for wildlife crime justice

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Feb. 18

Data from Nepal's courts in the last fiscal year (2022/23) reveals that 14 of 16 verdicts on forest and wildlife crimes convicted poor indigenous communities and only two persons were acquitted.

The experts, at a conference on 'Wildlife Conservation and Environmental Justice' that concluded on Saturday here, recommended integrating wildlife crime investigations and prosecutions into the legal framework with a focus on targeting only those involved.

They also suggested enacting specific forest-related laws, especially in countries like Nepal where indigenous communities are often targeted.

Discussions were centred on indigenous communities' rights to natural resources and the importance of judges taking environmental issues seriously.

Additionally, they also called for strict penalties for counterfeit hunting permits and for revising forest laws to prevent human rights violations.

Embracing advanced technologies in wildlife crime investigations is seen as crucial, along with implementing high-quality research methods, they said. Additionally, they stressed the need for capacity-building training programmes to enhance the skills of researchers involved investigations.

The joint conference organised by the Ministry of Forests and Environment, Judiciary Society Nepal, and National Trust for Nature Conservation recommended making coordination with government attorneys more effective when investigating wildlife crime incidents.

It also recommended the creation of a specialised unit for wildlife crime control and investigation in Nepal to support judicial proceedings. The participants suggested prioritising cases related to environmental crimes and wildlife crimes and integrating them into the judicial process.

They also recommended differentiating the handling of wildlife-related issues from the framework of regular criminal offences when formulating laws related to wildlife crime. They also emphasised recognising the role of the National Nature Conservation Fund of Nepal as an institution established by law. Discussions were mainly centred on the rights of indigenous communities over natural resources and the need for judges to take environmental issues seriously.

Speaking at the conference, Chief Justice Bishwambhar Prasad Shrestha mentioned that some decisions regarding wildlife conservation and environmental justice made by the court were yet to be implemented. He emphasized the need for attention from relevant parties for their implementation.

He stated, "There is a current need to achieve a balance between development and environmental sustainability for carbon emission reduction. Many laws related to forest, wildlife, and environmental conservation exist, but attention from relevant parties is necessary for their implementation," he said. Participants also asked for the revision of provisions in forest laws that could lead to human rights violations,

President Ramchandra Paudel, along with distinguished personalities from Nepal's judiciary sector such as Chief Justice Shrestha, Minister of Forests and Environment, Dr. Birendra Prasad Mahato, the Chairperson of the NTNC, Dr. Krishna Prasad Oli, and Member Secretary at NTNC Sharad Adhikari were present in the event.

There were three sessions at the conference. In the first session of the programme, Ambika Prasad Khatiwada, a senior conservation officer of the NTNC, presented on the Wildlife Crime Control Project, which has been operational with the support of various organizations including the Fund, the World Bank, and the United States Agency for International Development (USAID). The presentation aimed to foster cooperation between the judiciary and the Judiciary Society of Nepal in combating wildlife crimes.

Besisahar-Chame road blacktopped

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Manang, Feb. 18

The blacktopping of 7.8 kilometres road section of the Dumre-Besisahar-Chame Road, the only road network connecting Manang district, has been completed.

The construction work of the Dumre-Besisahar-Chame Road Project was started by the Road Division Office, Tanahun, in 1991, according to the government's plan to connect Manang with the road network.

Kiran Pokhrel, an engineer and information officer at the Dumre Besisahar-Chame Road Project office, said that only 700 metres of the road was left to be blacktopped. He said that 85 per cent of the work had been completed with expenditures totaling Rs.190 million.

According to the road project office, a contract for the project is expected to cost approximately Rs. 520 million, but the contract was awarded at Rs. 253.2 million in June 2021. However, due to the monsoon, construction work began only in September of the same year. Since the work could not be completed within the deadline, the contract was extended till July 2024.

Meanwhile, the construction of the road was handed over to the then Nepali Army in 2000 after the construction work was halted due to various reasons. Out of the 65-kilometres-long road, 35 kilometres lie in Lamjung and 30 kilometres in Manang.

Sub-engineer Suman Adhikari said that the construction work on the Manang section could not make progress rapidly due to excessive cold in winter.

He said that the work would be accelerated with the onset of summer.

Almost 29 years after the track was opened, the road section in Lamjung is being blacktopped by using American technology called Asphalt Paving Technology.



PHOTO: TRN

Blacktopped road section of the Dumre-Besisahar-Chame Road at Manang.

National Forum of Newar Journalists honours journos



PHOTO: TRN

Upesh Maharjan, Consulting Editor of the Gorkhapatra Corporation being honoured from National Forum of Newar Journalists for his significant contribution to promoting Nepal Bhasa, Newar culture and in issues of inclusiveness.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

National Forum of Newar Journalists honoured Upesh Maharjan, Consulting Editor of the Gorkhapatra Corporation, for his significant contribution to promoting Nepal Bhasa, Newar culture and in issues of inclusiveness.

He was honoured on the occasion of its 12th annual general meeting in Kathmandu on Saturday.

On the occasion, Kiran Shakya, Administrative Chief at Guthi Sansthan, and Danda Gurung, former chairman of the Federation of Nepalese Indigenous Journalists, were also honoured.

Similarly, six journalists were also honoured with cash prizes for their contribution to mother tongue journalism in Nepali media.

Bishwontar Shakya was awarded 'Gyan Jyoti Laxmi Prabha Award' carrying a purse of Rs. 20,000, Yuvraj Shrestha was awarded 'Gyandevi Mani Journalism Award' with a purse Rs. 15,000 and Uden Nhusayami was honoured 'Bhikchu Kumar Kashyap Memorial Journalism Award' of Rs. 12,000.

Similarly, Silviya Rajopadhyaya was honoured with 'Bangmaya Satabdi Purus Satya Mohan Joshi Journalism Award', Buddha Sharan Shahi was recognised with 'Baburaja Jyapu Photo Journalism' and Renu Tyanabasu with 'Shree Ram Memorial Journalism Award'. Each of these awards carried a purse of Rs. 10,000.

TREES PLANTED ON OCCASION OF DEMOCRACY DAY

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Feb. 18

On the occasion of Democracy Day, 150 saplings of apple trees were planted on the newly established office premises of the Armed Police Force, Nepal No. 33 Battalion in Tatopani Rural Municipality-4, Jumla district, on Sunday.

Chandannath Municipality Mayor Raju Singh Kathayat, Tatopani Rural Municipality Vice-chair Rewati Rawal, Chief District Officer, Jumla Jaya Kumar Ghimire, stakeholders and locals were present in the tree plantation programme.

According to Chief District Officer Ghimire, the saplings were planted in coordination with Division Forest Office, Horticulture Research Station, Prime Minister Agriculture Modernisation Project Implementation Unit Office, Agriculture Development Office and Tatopani Rural Municipality.

Chetraj Joshi, Superintendent of Armed Police Force Jumla, said that they had planted 150 saplings this time. He informed that earlier they had planted 1,025 saplings of various trees including saal, walnut, dhupi, devdar and apple.

21 (twenty-one) day subpoena Notice by Kaski District Court in the name of the person above mentioned.

As Mr. Anup Shrestha, an inhabitant of Pokhara Metropolitan City, Ward No. 17, Kaski District, has filed a case of Divorce (Case No. 079-CP-1776) against you, this notice of subpoena has been published in your name pursuant to the order of this court dated 25 January 2024. Therefore, be present at the court in person or send representative pursuant to law or law practitioner in the office time within 21 (twenty-one) days except the due time of travel from the date of publication of this notice with response claim or evidence of your documents. In case you do not be present with the response claim did not send representative or law practitioner within the deadline of time, the decree on the case shall be given as per law. **Particulars:**

1) Janean Kay Hajek, 60 years, granddaughter of Kenneth Jung, daughter of Gerald J Jung, wife of Anup Shrestha, inhabitant of Kaski District, Pokhara Metropolitan City, Ward No. 17, Damside Marga, House No. 47. **Date: 19 February, 2024.**

Case Section No. 23, Case No. 079-cp-6024

The Summons issued by the Kathmandu District Court

In the name of defendant Ms. Wai Kwan Virginia Fung, a resident of Ward No. 8 of Bidur Municipality, Nuwakot District, daughter of Mr. Fung Chion.

Whereas, Mr. Dhan Bahadur Tamang, a resident of Ward No. 7 of Bidur Municipality, Nuwakot District, filed in this Court a Petition for the case of Divorce against you, on Mar. 14, 2023; and Whereas, the summons issued in your name has been returned as being served as disappearance of the person; Now, therefore, the summons in your name has been published in The Rising Nepal National daily Newspaper pursuant to Sections 282 and 114 of the National Civil Procedures Code, 2017 as per the order dated Jan. 4, 2024 of this court. If you appear in this Court in person or through an attorney or legal practitioner according to law, alongwith a Statement of Defense and documentary evidence, as well, as per law, during office hours within 21 days, excluding the time required for journey, from the date of acknowledgment by you of this Summons or of the service of this Summons in accordance with law, the case shall be tried according to law. If you fail to submit the original and duplicate copies of your documentary evidence, along-with the Statement of Defense, it shall be as per law. If you fail to furnish the Statement of Defense and even to send an attorney or practitioner within the time limit, the case shall be adjudged according to law. Your subsequent claim shall not be entertained. **Done on Monday, Feb. 19, 2024.**

Case No:- 079-c1-0005 (Offence related to theft) Depart-3

Issued by Lalitpur District Court

This is to notify that the following individual is required to appear at Lalitpur District court in person within 35 days of this notice excluding the time required for journey as per the court Order for the hearing purpose of alleged Offence related to theft. Disregarding this notice will result in further legal action as per the prevailing laws of Nepal. **Monday, 19 February 2024.**

S. N.	Name	Name of the members of family	Permanent Adress	Temporary Adress	Age
1.	Ranjan podhar	Grandfather's Name:- Dharmendra Podhar Father's Name:- Wakil Podhar Mother's Name:- Nilam Devi	Jalalpur Bihar Post (848506), Bingama Samastipur, India	Kathmandu Metropolitan City, Ward no. 12 Teku, Kathmandu	27

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The wish for healing has always been half of health.Share this Quote
- Lucius Annaeus Seneca

EDITORIAL

Expedite Construction

The construction sector constitutes a vital component of national economy as it draws a huge investment from both government and the private sector. With spending on infrastructure, the sector stimulate economy in time of recession. In the Nepali context, construction industry gets involved in building big infrastructure such as highways, hydropower, real estate, irrigation, dams, public utilities and government buildings. When a big amount of capital is mobilised, hundreds of thousands of jobs are created, thereby helping the people solve their livelihood problems and lead a life of dignity. It employs skilled, unskilled and seasonal workers. It has been the largest employer in the country. Around 400,000 youths enter the labour force in Nepal annually and the construction sector absorbs significant number of them. If the sector flounders, this will have negative repercussions for job opportunities and economic growth.

However, a news report, carried by this daily on Sunday, shows that the construction sector is passing through hard times due to the decreased loan mobilisation, high interest rates, restriction on land plots, crisis in the cooperative sector and share market crash. Both the public and private construction sectors have been reeling from crisis for the past more than one year, hitting the business of construction materials such as cement, iron bars, paints, pipes and fittings, electric goods, furniture and decorative items. The trade of pipes and fittings has declined by 40-50 per cent as the people are not constructing private houses. Only medium and large industries and some housing projects are involved in construction and maintenance works.

Due to construction decline, production of cement factories has exceeded the domestic demand and the manufacturers have requested the government to bring alternative schemes to boost the infrastructure development to increase the demand for cement. A Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) study reveals that the manufacturing sector ran on an average of 42 per cent of its capacity in the first half of the last Fiscal Year 2022/23 as the approval for the blueprint of house construction went down by 37.5 per cent during the same period. The steel industry is running below 40 per cent due to the low development spending and liquidity on the part of common people.

The iron industries are said to be on the verge of collapse as the government has imposed a 5 per cent import duty and Rs. 2.5 per kg excise duty on MS Billets, the key raw material for iron bars. The construction industry was providing direct employment to 2 to 2.5 million people, but around 1.5 million people have been laid off due to the ongoing recession. It is necessary to give impetus to the implementation of projects given that about 1,800 projects worth Rs. 400 billion are awaiting deadline extensions. The government bears a liability to clear Rs. 40 billion to the contractors while it has to pay around Rs. 10 billion to them for the under construction projects.

Over 800 projects are pending owing to the glitches related to the land acquisition, budget and design. With the government ban on the illegal crusher industries, there was a shortage of stone, sand and gravel, affecting the sector. There is a rise in the remittance inflow but it is not being spent on productive sectors. At the moment, Nepal needs to invest massively in infrastructure for the development of agriculture, industries and public utilities. This will boost capital spending and give a fillip to the construction sector.

Tea Chat That Animates

PALLAV BHUSAL

In the heart of Kathmandu lies Basantapur, a bustling square steeped in history, culture, and the essence of daily life. Amidst the maze of narrow streets and ancient architecture, there exists a timeless tradition that transcends generations: tea chat. The age-old ritual that carries camaraderie and animating conversation has been an integral party of Nepalis' social life for centuries. Yet, in our modern, fast-paced world, the culture of tea chat risks fading into obscurity.

As the sun spreads its golden glow over Basantapur, the aroma of varieties of tea permeates the air, beckoning passers-by to pause, sip, and connect. Here, beneath the shade of centuries-old temples and pagodas, people from all walks of life gather around makeshift tea stalls, their laughter mingling with the clinking of ceramic cups. In this shared space, strangers become friends, and friends become family, united by the simple pleasure of good company and warm tea.

However, amidst the hustle and bustle of 21st-century life, the pace of our existence has accelerated, leaving little room for the unhurried conversations and genuine connections that tea chat affords. In our relentless pursuit of productivity and progress, we risk sacrificing the very essence of what makes us human: our ability to connect, empathise, and share our stories.

But the importance of tea chat extends far beyond mere socialisation. It serves as a powerful antidote to the isolation and disconnection that plague our modern society. In a world dominated by screens and social media, the act of sitting down face-to-face, savouring a cup of tea, and engaging in meaningful conversation is a radical act of resistance against the forces of alienation and division.

Moreover, tea chat offers a much-needed reprieve from the stresses and strains of daily life. In the tranquil confines of Basantapur, time seems to slow down, allowing us to savour the present moment and appreciate the beauty of our surroundings. Here, amidst the ancient temples and markets, we are reminded of the richness and complexity of life, and the importance of taking a moment to pause, reflect, and connect with those around us.

As we navigate an increasingly fragmented and polarised world, the tradition of tea chat fosters friendship and harmony. It reminds us that, despite our differences, we are all bound together by our shared values, and that true happiness lies not in material wealth or worldly success, but in the simple pleasures of good company and meaningful conversation.

In Basantapur's vibrant tapestry, the tradition of tea chat is not merely a relic of the past, but a living testament to the enduring power of human connection. As we navigate the challenges of the modern world, let us not overlook the invaluable lessons imparted by this age-old ritual. Let us make time to sit, sip, and savour the company of our fellow travellers on this journey called life. For in the simple act of sharing tea and conversation, we find solace, solidarity, and the profound realisation that, despite our differences, we are all in this together.

So let us raise our cups to the timeless tradition of tea chat, and pledge to keep its flame burning bright for generations to come. For in this humble ritual lies the key to unlocking the full potential of life, one cup of tea at a time.

Democracy Is All About Delivery



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

Marking the ushering of modern democracy in Nepal back in 1951 offers an opportunity to discuss briefly what it means, or should mean. Perceptions differ; so also do definitions. Some common features are, however, natural and acceptable. Of prime importance are reducing poverty, meeting the basic needs of a maximum number of people and ensuring core freedoms that engage members of society in airing their views and desires without fear. Nursing animus against dissenting voices is no democratic approach. But democracy cannot be strengthened amid hungry stomachs.

Educated unemployed represents a crude state of affairs, reflecting the victims' depth of pain and anguish. Trouble breeds if multiple adults, if not all, in a family are without regular jobs. Extended families might help ease the situation slightly in meeting minimum needs but this cannot go on endlessly in this day and age. Suitable jobs for the employable age adults meet the most basic of requirements for a successfully functioning polity.

An environment for free expression without consequences adds to the quality of the polity and also addresses an array of issues concerning participatory democracy. At a time when there is so much talk about democracy, it is in the fitness of things to dwell upon a debate on global democracy. Some countries commit themselves to promoting democracy in other states. They do not hesitate to become proactive in attempts at exporting their ideas of how states should function.

Correction course

If the criteria set by some Western agencies concentrating their attention on conditions in various parts of the world are anything to go by, less than a quarter of the global community of independent states are advanced democracies. The United Nations could make significant contributions to promoting democracy worldwide. Its Security Council, however, does not reflect the spirit of universal representation in the new millennium without revamping its composition. The presence of a select five holding permanent seats constitutes a glaring contradiction. Moreover, the manner in which the five individual members exercise the veto power to quash initiatives robs the vast majority of the rest of the largest international body of their voice concerning vital issues.

The practice goes against the principles of inclusive and participatory process. At the same time, no country from Africa and Latin America is represented. In terms of population and number of countries, the Security Council's composition leaves much to be desired. In fact, the anomaly was pointed out right from the beginning after World War II ended in 1945, when colonialism was still at its height. If the UN had 51 founder member states, the total now has risen nearly four times at 193. Struggle for independence from colonial rule, and divisions of territories based on sectarian factors brought about many new independent nations.

Of the "Big Five" holding permanent seats, Russia (formerly the Soviet Union) has used veto power 121 times, the US 82 times, the United Kingdom 29 times, China 17 times and France 16 times. France and the UK have not invoked their veto power since 1989. Animus against different ideas is no democratic approach. Use of intimidation, sponsoring of proxy war and inciting violence are to be denounced. Although an essential element in improving the living standards of the people in a given state, economic prosperity alone does not ensure democratic governance.

> At the end of the day, the quality of democracy is gauged by a delivery that meets the expectations of well-informed and proactive units of all sections of society.

Various groups list only a few countries as full democracies and the rest of humanity are graded partly democratic, flawed democracy and the like. Flawed voting affects voter participation even in advanced democracies. Minimising hassles and rigmaroles should be a priority. The new times of a fast-changing world cannot march forward smoothly and in the spirit of global cooperation without maximum participation of the largest number of people in setting agendas; defining and interpreting issues; and the like. Extended class culture, inherent inequality and depressing disparity that cut-throat capitalism cultivates do not aid functioning democracy.

The good-doing group with hidden agenda is conspiratorial and complicit in manufacturing poison-drips. Traditionally dominant powers' long-nurtured image of invincibility has begun to crack and risks collapse in the not-too-distant future. The stench of blatant expediency, which eats into state structures held by democracy's self-declared champions, erodes much of the promised good governance. As a result, assertions of defining, interpreting and evaluating democracy for the entire world will sound empty.

Attitude & approach

Many sections criticise the US-led war in Iraq as a humanitarian crime. They worry about the lack of transparency in their elected representatives. Carl Bernstein, of the investigative reports pertaining to the Watergate scandal, made in partnership with Bob Woodward for The Washington Post, notes: "Our democracy, before Trump, had ceased to be working well." A recent survey indicated that 49 per cent of Britons look back at their colonial rule as "good old days". In the 1980s, US President Ronald Reagan sold weapons clandestinely to Iran through a circuitous route for circumventing senate's directive not to fund the Contras who were fighting against Nicaragua's ruling Sandinista leftists.

Most Russians praise Putin for restoring their national pride as against his two immediate predecessors Mikhail Gorbachev and Boris Yeltsin — among the favourite Russians in the West — or Hamid Karzai and Mohammad Ashraf Ghani in Afghanistan. Putin is no less aggressive than his foreign counterparts when it comes to the question of national "security interests". Many American analysts consider America's support for the Israeli annexation of the Golan Heights to be uncalled for. Without the near $ 4 billion in annual US military support to the Jewish state, events might have been drastically different from those unfolding presently in West Asia.

Only if those in the seat of power play by the rule book does credibility get bolstered. Democratic governance can be improved and strengthened through regular and timely political debates that enable citizens to fulfil their social responsibility. Informed citizen participation helps in critical appreciation of state affairs at the mass level. At the end of the day, the quality of democracy is gauged by a delivery that meets the expectations of well-informed and proactive units of all sections of society. Most people in developing countries list health services, education, employment and law and order as top priorities.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Retain Public Confidence In Judiciary



Anupam Bhattarai

The rulings of Nepal's courts have far-reaching effects outside of courtrooms in the country's developing legal system. Every choice, painstakingly entwined with the legal system, has the power to alter the social structure, political landscape, and economic course of the country. Examining the impacts of these decisions reveals a maze of interrelated paths, each of which leads to a distinct and frequently complex result. Like a pebble thrown into a pond, the decisions made by the court have implications for its social, political, and economic environment. Analysing the effects of these rulings reveals a complicated web of planned and unexpected outcomes, emphasising the authority and difficulties that come with making choices as a judge.

Rulings on matters of social justice, such as the legalisation of same-sex marriage, are met with enthusiasm but also controversy over its application and opposition from some quarters. It emphasises the necessity for careful navigating between sustaining legal principles and promoting social cohesiveness. The court becomes a battlefield for conflicting narratives about development and tradition. The decision have sparked hope, especially for underprivileged groups. For example, the acceptance of same-sex marriage was a turning point in the struggle for LGBTQ+ rights. But it's still a difficult challenge to turn such declarations into actualities.

Political currents

Difficulties with implementation, driven by social disapproval and insufficient legal structures, can stifle development of society. Similar tales emerge in fields such as environmental protection and gender equality, where resource limitations and entrenched traditions make it difficult for judges to overturn rulings. The decisions made by the judiciary frequently find themselves at the intersection of opposing political currents. Decisions made on matters such as citizenship, federalism, and the dissolution of parliament have rocked the political spectrum and shown the complex and occasionally tense relationship between the several arms of government.

Although maintaining the rule of law is crucial, there is some ambiguity due to worries about judicial overreach and political meddling. In order to navigate this difficult terrain, it becomes imperative to ensure fair and unbiased interpretations that are free from undue influence. The country's economic engine can be greatly impacted by the decisions made by the judiciary.

Decisions made over taxation, intellectual property rights, and land acquisition have a direct impact on the business environment and the atmosphere for investment. Maintaining legal standards while promoting economic expansion requires a careful tango. Promoting investments and business ventures needs to be in line with making sure that land acquisition costs are fairly compensated for, that tax systems are fair, and that intellectual property rights are well protected.

> Rebuilding public confidence requires actions to assure accountability, speed up procedures, and promote openness.

Striking a balance is essential to Nepal's economic health. Its most precious resource, public confidence in the judiciary, can be undermined by irregularities in rulings, delays in case settlement, and accusations of corruption. The judicial system's fundamental base is weakened by this loss, making it more difficult for it to properly administer justice. Rebuilding public confidence requires actions to assure accountability, speed up procedures, and promote openness. Establishing a feeling of shared ownership and legitimacy may be facilitated by having open dialogues with the public, media, and civil society.

The effects of court rulings don't only happen right away. Setting precedents via landmark decisions can influence how the law is understood and implemented in subsequent instances. Conversely, controversial choices might lead to social movements and public debate calling for reform. The outside community also pays attention, since court rulings influence how the world views Nepal, affecting diplomatic ties and the country's status there. A diverse strategy is needed to navigate the complicated terrain of judicial implications.

Public trust

Crucial responsibilities include maintaining public trust, guaranteeing accessibility and efficiency, and striking the correct balance between conflicting interests. Proclamations and lived realities can be brought closer together by eliminating judicial vacancies, streamlining court procedures, and advancing legal aid. Rebuilding public confidence may be achieved via embracing responsibility, being transparent, and having open discussions. Ultimately, Nepal's judiciary can cement its position as a pillar of a just and equitable society by pursuing a path that places a premium on justice, impartiality, and inclusion.

Richer insights may be gained by delving further into particular historic choices and their complex outcomes. A more complete picture is also painted when the localised effects of court decisions—especially on underprivileged communities — are taken into account. We may better comprehend the significant and far-reaching effects of court rulings in Nepal by tying these many strands together.

(The author is an advocate.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 19, 1974

New Postage Stamps Issued

Kathmandu, Feb. 18: To mark the Tribhuvan Memorial and National Democracy Day, two types of postage stamps were issued here this morning, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Save Pangolins From Extinction



The news story your daily carried, *"Save pangolins from poaching and illegal trade: Conservationists"*, highlights the grave danger pangolins find themselves in, as well as the initiatives taken, particularly by the organisation Greenhood Nepal alongside Panchpandab Buffer Zone Users' Commiee of Chitwan National Park (CNP), to save the world's most trafficked wild mammal from brink of extinction.

Saving pangolins has been at the core of wildlife programme for many years. These extraordinary creature are prized for their meat, which is considered a delicacy, and for its scales, which are used in traditional Chinese medicine – the reasons why they are smuggled out of the country.

Given their alarmingly dwindling number, it has become more urgent to save them from being extinct. Those in their conservation deserve a pat on the back, but that's not enough; those in buying and selling business must also be held accountable. It's a matter of pride that we are still a home to about 5000 pangolins. Saving them is our responsibility.

Binaya Rawal
Hetauda

TAILPIECE

A police officer sees a man driving around with a pickup truck full of penguins. He pulls the guy over and says, "You can't drive around with penguins in this town! Take them to the zoo immediately."

The guy obliges and drives away.

The next day, the officer sees the same guy driving around with the truck full of penguins again. This time, though, all the penguins are wearing sunglasses.

The police officer pulls the guy over and says, "I thought I told you to take these penguins to the zoo yesterday?"

The guy replies, "I did, and today I'm taking them to the beach."

Over 400 detained in Russia while honouring Navalny

AFP
Russia, Feb. 18



PHOTO: AFP

Police officers detain a woman during a gathering in memory of Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny in Moscow, Russia, on February 17, 2024.

Over 400 people were detained in Russia while paying tribute to opposition leader Alexei Navalny, who died at a remote Arctic penal colony, a prominent rights group reported.

The sudden death of Navalny, 47, was a crushing blow to many Russians, who had pinned their hopes for the future on President Vladimir Putin's fiercest foe. Navalny remained vocal in his unrelenting criticism of the Kremlin even after surviving a nerve agent poisoning and receiving multiple prison terms.

The news reverberated across the globe, and hundreds of people in dozens of Russian cities streamed to ad-hoc memorials and monuments to victims of political repressions with flowers and candles on Friday and Saturday to pay a tribute to the politician. In over a dozen cities, police detained 401 people by Saturday night, according to the OVD-Info rights group that tracks political arrests and provides legal aid.

More than 200 arrests were made in St. Petersburg, Russia's second largest city, the group said. Among those detained there was Grigory Mikhnov-Voitenko, a priest of the Apostolic Orthodox Church — a religious group independent of the Russian Orthodox Church — who announced plans on social media to hold a memorial service for Navalny and was arrested on Saturday morning outside his home. He was charged with organizing a rally and placed in a holding cell in a police precinct, but was later hospitalised with a stroke, OVD-Info reported.

Courts in St. Petersburg have ordered 42 of those detained on Friday to serve from one to six days in jail, while nine others were fined, court officials said late on Saturday. In Moscow, at least six people were ordered to serve 15 days in jail, according to OVD-Info. One person was also jailed in the southern city of Krasnodar and two more in the city of Bryansk, the group said.

The news of Navalny's death came a month before a presidential election in Russia that is widely expected to give President Vladimir Putin another six years in power. Questions about the cause of death lingered on Sunday, and it remained unclear when the authorities would release his body to his family.

Navalny's team said Saturday that the politician was "murdered" and accused the authorities of deliberately stalling the release of the body, with Navalny's mother and lawyers getting contradicting information from various institutions where they went in their quest to retrieve the body. "They're driving us around in circles and covering their tracks," Navalny's spokeswoman, Kira Yarmysh, said on Saturday.

"Everything there is covered with cameras in the colony. Every step he took was filmed from all angles all these years. Each employee has a video recorder. In two days, there has been not a single video leaked or published. There is no room for uncertainty here," Navalny's closest ally and strategist Leonid Volkov said Sunday.

A note handed to Navalny's mother stated that he died at 2:17 p.m. Friday, according to Yarmysh. Prison officials told his mother when she arrived at the penal colony Saturday that her son had perished from "sudden death syndrome," Ivan Zhdanov, the director of Navalny's Anti-Corruption Foundation, wrote on X, formerly known as Twitter.

Thai ex-Prime Minister Thaksin gets free on parole

AP
Bangkok, Feb. 18



PHOTO: AP

Former Thai Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra sits in a vehicle after being released on parole Sunday, Feb. 18, 2024, in Bangkok, Thailand.

Thailand's former Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra, the Southeast Asian nation's controversial politician for more than two decades, was released on parole early Sunday from a Bangkok hospital where he spent six months serving time for corruption-related offenses.

The telecoms billionaire was toppled in a 2006 coup but voluntarily returned from self-exile to Thailand in August last year and reported to prison to begin serving an eight-year sentence. Critics charged that the 74-year-old Thaksin's early release reeked of a deal that short-circuited justice for political reasons. Current Prime Minister Srettha Thavisin, a leading member of the ruling Thaksin-backed Pheu Thai party, expressed congratulations to his predecessor.

Thaksin was seen wearing a neck brace, a sling on his right arm and a surgical mask inside one of the cars in a convoy that left the Police General Hospital just before sunrise. He was accompanied by his two daughters on his way to his residence in western Bangkok.

"Thaksin is still believed to wield huge influence, and will still maneuver for sure, he will conduct the music behind the scenes," Thitinan Pongsudhirak, a political science professor at Bangkok's Chulalongkorn University, said.

"But Pheu Thai has less power than they used to and we'll have to see how he does it."

After his return from exile, Thaksin was moved almost immediately to the hospital on grounds of ill health and about a week later, King Maha Vajiralongkorn reduced his sentence to a single year.

The former leader had won unprecedented electoral support but also influential enemies among Thailand's traditional royalist ruling class during his time in office in 2001-2006.

He was accused of corruption and abuse of power as well as disrespect for the monarchy when the military removed him from power in 2006. Thailand's conservative elite, including the army, regarded his popularity and brash populist politics as a threat to the royal institution, which they see as a linchpin of Thai society.

Even after his ouster, Thaksin's supporters and opponents had continued their struggle for power with violent street fighting, election battles, confrontations in the courts and another coup in 2014 that ousted a government that had been formed by Thaksin's sister.

Last year's elections brought change when the progressive Move Forward party unexpectedly finished first, the first time since 2001 that a Thaksin-backed party failed to top the polls. Move Forward's proposals for reforms to the monarchy and the military resonated with large numbers of younger voters, weary of the army-backed governments that had held power since a 2014 coup.

UN court to hear on Israeli occupation of Palestinian-claimed lands

AP
Netherlands, Feb. 18



PHOTO: AP

A view of the Peace Palace, which houses the International Court of Justice, or World Court, in The Hague, Netherlands, on Jan. 26, 2024.

The United Nations' highest court opens historic hearings Monday into the legality of Israel's 57-year occupation of lands sought for a Palestinian state, plunging the 15 international judges back into the heart of the decades-long Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

Six days of hearings are scheduled at the International Court of Justice, during which an unprecedented number of countries will participate, as Israel continues its devastating assault on Gaza.

Though the case occurs against the backdrop of the Israel-Hamas war, it focuses instead on Israel's open-ended occupation of the West Bank, Gaza and east Jerusalem.

Palestinian representatives, who speak first on Monday, will argue that the Israeli occupation is illegal because it has violated three key tenets of international law, the Palestinian legal team told reporters Wednesday.

They say that Israel has violated the prohibition on territorial conquest by annexing large swaths of occupied land, has violated the Palestinians' right to self-determination, and has imposed a system of racial discrimination and apartheid.

"We want to hear new words from the court," said Omar Awadallah, the head of the U.N. organizations department in the Palestinian Foreign Ministry.

"They've had to consider the word genocide in the South Africa case," he said, referring to a separate case before the court. "Now we want them to consider apartheid."

Awadallah said an advisory opinion from the court "will give us many tools, using peaceful international law methods and tools, to confront the illegalities of the occupation."

The court will likely take months to rule. But experts say the decision, though not legally binding, could profoundly impact international jurisprudence, international aid to Israel and public opinion.

"The case will put before the court a litany of accusations and allegations and grievances which are probably going to be uncomfortable and embarrassing for Israel, given the war and the already very polarized international environment," said Yuval Shany, a law professor at Hebrew University and senior fellow at the Israel Democracy Institute.

Israel is not scheduled to speak during the hearings, but could submit a written statement. Shany said Israel will likely justify the ongoing occupation on security grounds, especially in the absence of a peace deal.

Republican opponent takes stance against aiding Ukraine

AP
Munich, Feb. 18

> Halting weapons supplies to Ukraine now would mean that "either you are prolonging the war or you give up Ukraine and Putin wins," she said.

A Republican opponent of new U.S. funding for Ukraine argued at an international security conference Sunday that the package stuck in Congress wouldn't "fundamentally change the reality" on the ground and that Russia has an incentive to negotiate peace.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, U.S. Vice President Kamala Harris and others have advocated passage of the $60 billion in aid at the Munich Security Conference, which coincided with Ukraine withdrawing troops from the eastern city of Avdiivka after months of intense combat.

But Sen. J.D. Vance, an Ohio Republican and ally of Donald Trump, said "the problem in Ukraine ... is that there's no clear end point" and that the U.S. doesn't make enough weapons to support wars in eastern Europe, the Middle East and "potentially a contingency in East Asia."

House Speaker Mike Johnson insists he won't be "rushed" into approving the $95.3 billion foreign aid package from the Senate that includes the help for Ukraine, despite overwhelming support from most Democrats and almost half the Republicans.

If the package goes through, "that is not going to fundamentally change the reality on the battlefield," Vance argued, pointing to limited American manufacturing capacity.

Ricarda Lang, a co-leader of one of Germany's governing parties, the Greens, responded that Russian President Vladimir Putin has shown repeatedly "that he has no interest in peace at the moment."

Halting weapons supplies to Ukraine now would mean that "either you are prolonging the war or you give up Ukraine and Putin wins," she said.

If Putin wins, "he, but also other forces like China, are going to learn that it's possible to just change borders and that NATO is not going to hold it against us," Lang added. That would lead to "a world with less security, and ... a world with less freedom for the EU but also for the U.S."

PRISM

Book returned to library after 93 years

Ohio: An Ohio library said a patron recently brought something surprising to librarians -- a poetry book that was 93 years overdue.

The Licking County Library in Newark said on social media that Heart Throbs: The Old Scrap Book, a book containing poetry from thousands of authors, was recently returned to the library by a patrol. The patron told librarians she had found the book among the belongings in her great aunt's house.

The tome still contains a list of rules from what was then called the Public Library of Newark. The card states that a charge of 2 cents per day would be incurred for each day the book is overdue.

Lion cub tries pulling siblings off rock

South Africa: These six lion cubs were feeling bored until they found a long grass root to play tug of war with. Then the cutest chaos began, and it was all fun and games.

Pieter Van Wyk, a guide at MalaMala in South Africa, witnessed this adorable sighting and shared the video with LatestSightings.com.

It all started with the cubs and their mother relaxing after a long night out. Mom was tired, but her cubs were full of energy to burn. They were looking for something to keep them busy when one cub found the perfect toy - a long piece of root that had been plucked from the ground!

(AP)

Monument lists over 125,000 names of Japanese American WWII detainees

AP
Los Angeles, Feb 18



PHOTO: AP

In this photo provided by the National Archives, Japanese Americans from San Pedro, Calif., arrive at the Santa Anita Assembly Centre in Arcadia, Calif., on April 5, 1942.

Samantha Sumiko Pinedo and her grandparents file into a dimly lit enclosure at the Japanese American National Museum and approach a massive book splayed open to reveal columns of names. Pinedo is hoping the list includes her great-grandparents, who were detained in Japanese American incarceration camps during World War II.

"For a lot of people, it feels like so long ago because it was World War II. But I grew up with my Bompa (great-grandpa), who was in the internment camps," Pinedo says.

A docent at the museum in Los Angeles gently flips to the middle of the book — called the Ireicho — and locates Kaneo Sakatani near the center of a page. This was Pinedo's great-grandfather, and his family can now honor him.

On Feb. 19, 1942, following the attack by Imperial Japan on Pearl Harbor and the United States' entry to WWII, President Franklin D. Roosevelt signed Executive Order 9066 authorizing the incarceration of people of Japanese ancestry who were considered potentially dangerous.

From the extreme heat of the Gila River center in Arizona, to the biting winters of Heart Mountain in Wyoming, Japanese Americans were forced into hastily built barracks, with no insulation or privacy, and surrounded by barbed wire. They shared bathrooms and mess halls, and families of up to eight were squeezed into 20-by-25 foot (6-by-7.5 meter) rooms. Armed U.S. soldiers in guard towers ensured nobody tried to flee.

Approximately two-thirds of the detainees were American citizens.

When the 75 holding facilities on U.S. soil closed in 1946, the government published Final Accountability Rosters listing the name, sex, date of birth and marital status of the Japanese Americans held at the 10 largest facilities. There was no clear consensus of who or how many had been detained nationwide.

Duncan Ryuken Williams, the director of the Shinso Ito Center for Japanese Religions and Culture at the University of Southern California, knew those rosters were incomplete and riddled with errors, so he and a team of researchers took on the mammoth task of identifying all the detainees and honoring them with a three-part monument called "Irei: National Monument for the WWII Japanese American Incarceration."

"We wanted to repair that moment in American history by thinking of the fact that this is a group of people, Japanese Americans, that was targeted by the government. As long as you had one drop of Japanese blood in you, the government told you didn't belong," Williams said.

The Irei project was inspired by stone Buddhist monuments called Ireitos that were built by detainees at camps in Manzanar, California, and Amache, Colorado, to memorialize and console the spirits of internees who died.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1714 – Great Northern War: The battle of Napue between Sweden and Russia is fought in Isokyrö, Ostrobothnia.
1726 – The Supreme Privy Council is established in Russia.
1884 – More than sixty tornadoes strike the Southern United States, one of the largest tornado outbreaks in U.S. history.
1942 – World War II: Nearly 250 Japanese warplanes attack the northern Australian city of Darwin, killing 243 people.
1942 – World War II: United States President Franklin D. Roosevelt signs executive order 9066, allowing the United States military to relocate Japanese Americans to internment camps.
1960 – China successfully launches the T-7, its first sounding rocket.
2012 – Forty-four people are killed in a prison brawl in Apodaca, Nuevo León, Mexico.



PHOTO: SAGAR BASNET/TRN

Kids playing in a park in Chovar, Kathmandu.

NC president Deuba to open Mahasamiti meeting today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Nepali Congress has said that it has completed all necessary preparations for its General Committee (Mahasamiti) meeting which is beginning in Godavari, Lalitpur, on Monday.

Meen Bahadur Bishwakarma, the head of the Congress Publicity Department, addressed the media at the Godavari Sunrise Conference Centre on Sunday, confirming the party's readiness for the Mahasamiti meeting.

The party has also established its media centre to disseminate information about the meeting in Godavari.

Bishwakarma highlighted that the main objective of the General Committee, set to take place in Godavari from February 19 to 22, is to formulate the party's policy. Congress President and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba is scheduled to inaugurate the meeting at 1 pm on Monday.

During the session, reports on policy formulation, organisational structures, contemporary political issues, the current economic situation of Nepal, and the audit report approved by the central working committee meeting on February 16 would be presented for discussions.

Bishwakarma mentioned that the reports would be discussed in separate groups, ensuring representation from the Tarai, Madhes, Mountain, and Hilly regions in four designated halls.

With 165 central office bearers and members, and 1780 general committee members elected from 165 federal parliament constituencies, observers and others are expected to participate in the jamboree.

Bishwakarma expressed confidence that the discussions would underscore the Nepal Congress's commitment to addressing the current political environment and working faithfully for positive societal change.

Additionally, 89 individuals from the Nepali Public Relations Committee, 69 from fraternal and benevolent organisations, along with provincial, district, and central presidents of these groups, who are not general committee members, have been invited to the meeting, according to Bishwakarma.

MADHES CM YADAV PROVES MAJORITY FOR THIRD TIME

BY DHARBENDRA JHA
Dhanusha, Feb. 18

Chief Minister of Madhes Province Saroj Kumar Yadav has proved his majority in the Madhes Province Assembly for the third time.

In a voting held on Sunday, Chief Minister Yadav garnered 69 votes while 35 went against him. A total of 104 of 107 members of the Provincial Assembly were present during the floor test.

Announcing the result, Speaker Ram Chandra Mandal said that Chief Minister Yadav proved his majority.

Democracy...

"I believe that this day will inspire all people's representative organisations, political parties and all parts of the state to move forward in the direction of meeting people's expectations by adopting democratic values and norms," he said.

Likewise, Vice President Yadav said that Loktantra is the best governance system in the world.

Stating that only Loktantra could be an alternative to Loktantra, Vice President Yadav said that commitment not only from the government but also from all political parties, civil society, private sector and the media was required to make Loktantra more effective.

'Federal democracy has...

Similarly, Federal Education Act, Forest Act and Land Act which have been seen as obstacles to national development also need to be passed from the present session of the House. Federal Education Act is another important act to implement and exercise the concept of federalism.

It's been a long time, since we have come through the signing of the Comprehensive Peace Accord (CPA) and still transitional justice process has not been ended because of the differences between the political parties due to which, no specific provision could not be arranged in the act regarding transitional justice. Taking transitional justice to a logical end should be the issue and subject of the nation. It should be not an agenda or bargaining tool of any abstract party. That is why, we have been seeking national consensus and agreement among the parties to conclude the transitional justice. The government wishes to endorse this transitional justice-related act through the present session of the parliament. Thus, the government has accorded a high priority to introduce all necessary laws that hinder to implementation of the federalism and democratic system.

■ What are the current coalition government's plans to revive the economy hit by the Coronavirus and earthquake?

When the present government took office, the national economy was in a critical situation. Although the economy has revived to a significant degree the goals are yet to be achieved.

Today, all the ministries have been instructed to bring highly prioritised projects and plans that can be implemented instantly so that the government can also invest and earn more revenue. That is why, the PM and Minister for Finance have been holding several levels of meetings to attract more investment. The government has also working on the 16th Plan, and we are also planning to introduce some intervening types of projects through an upcoming policy and programmes of the government to create more jobs within the country keeping the national economy at the centre.

■ What are the plans, programmes and vision that the government has to stop the present brain-drain trend citing the lack of job opportunities here?

The first thing to short out this problem is the creation of more jobs within the country. The government is selecting such projects which can create the possibility of more jobs. Reviving the sick industries and investment in the IT sector from the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology can create more jobs in the future. Similarly, the investment in the tourism and agriculture sectors can create more jobs. Currently, there are two types of people going abroad, one strata of people are who have real problems sustaining their family and livelihood and another type of people are going out despite opportunities here. By creating more job opportunities we can retain the people who go abroad due to the lack of job opportunities at home.

■ The government especially the MoCIT has been seen active in regulating social media by introducing cyber security policy. What necessary planning is being made by the Ministry in this regard?

The government is establishing a separate cyber security centre after the endorsement of the cyber security policy. The sector of information technology and communication is very dynamic and changing all the time. But, our national laws and policies made in this sector are very old. That is why the Ministry is preparing to draft and introduce IT and communication sector-related laws at the earliest possible. The government has its understanding that any social media platform which we operate here must operate and function adhering to our national laws and policy. And under this understanding, we have tried to regulate some of the social media platforms. Today, TikTok has approached the government for its reoperation, and they have submitted their application to the government for opening the service with a commitment to adhering to Nepal's law and policy.

■ As we are marking Democracy Day today, what message do want to give on this special day when the regressive forces are raising their heads?

The Seventh of Falgun marks a huge achievement made by the people in establishing Democracy by overthrowing the autocratic Rana regime. On this day we commemorate the heroes who fought for the country. We have been able to establish a federal democratic republic due to the sacrifice of many freedom fighters.

Some elements have been trying to portray that this achievement has been gained out of nothing. The elements which have been trying to take advantage of the free and transparent political situation, will not succeed. Democracy has given voice to the people. At the same time, we all should realise our weaknesses, and mistakes to make this system stronger and trustworthy.

CIAA files charge sheet against 15 individuals

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) filed a graft case against 15 individuals including three former board chairpersons of the Melamchi Water Supply Development Board (MWSDB) and former secretaries at the Ministry of Water Supply.

The CIAA filed the case on charge of irregularities in the Melamchi Drinking Water Project at the Special Court, Kathmandu on Sunday. According to the CIAA, Eptisa Services De Ingenieris S.L., BETS Consulting Services Ltd. and CMC di Ravena were also found to be involved in irregularities and all three have been presented as defendants.

The CIAA has demanded a total fine of Rs. 6.6 billion from all defendants and punishment in accordance with Article 17 of the Prevention of Corruption Act-2002.

Former chairpersons of MWSDB and former secretaries at the Ministry of Water Supply Dr. Sanjay Sharma, Bhim Prasad Upadhyaya and Gajendra Kumar Thakur have been named in the charge sheet. The CIAA has demanded a fine of Rs. 69.78 million from Sharma, Rs. 41.13 million from Upadhyaya and Rs. 604.91 million from Thakur.

Similarly, the CIAA has demanded a fine of Rs. 69.78 million from Mukunda Prasad Paudel, a former joint secretary of the Finance Ministry and former board member.

Likewise, CIAA has demanded a fine of Rs. 110 million from former board member of MWSDB, Rudra Singh Tamang, and Rs. 715 million from MWSDB board member Chandra Bahadur Thapa. The CIAA also named MWSDB former executive directors Ghana Shyam Bhattarai, Ram Chandra Devkota and Surya Raj Kandel in the charge sheet. It demanded a fine of Rs. 227 million from Bhattarai, Rs. 323 million from Devkota and Rs. 890 million from Kandel.

The CIAA demanded a fine of Rs. 323 million each from Mani Bhadra Neupane, MWSDB former under secretary (accounts), Ram Chandra Neupane, MWSDB former accounts officer, Begnath Paudel, MWSDB former under secretary (accounts).

Likewise, MWSDB former under secretary (accounts) Kedar Prasad Ayarl has been demanded to be fined Rs. 447 million and MWSDB former senior engineer Bhoj Bikram Thapa Rs. 323 million. The CIAA demanded Shiva Kumar Sharma, former deputy team leader of Eptisa, BETS J/V to be fined Rs. 483 million. It demanded a fine of Rs. 875 million from Eptisa Services De Ingenieris S.L. and BETS Consulting Services Ltd. and Rs. 651 to CMC di Ravena.

PM expresses firm resolve to ensure...

from the recent Sankalpa Yatra for Prosperity led by the CPN (UML) Chairman KP Sharma Oli.

Prime Minister Prachanda highlighted the government's commitment to address migration challenges. He mentioned the ongoing implementation of the Madhyapahadi Lokmarga (Mid-Hill Highway) from Chiwabhanjyang in Panchthar to Jhulaghat in Baitadi, aimed at promoting balanced development in economic, social, cultural, tourism, educational, and other sectors in the region.

"Additionally, the government is working on 10 new city-integrated development plans and the last two strategic urban development plans to boost economic activities through agriculture, tourism, education, and industry," said PM Prachanda.

Regarding the suggestions obtained from the Sankalpa Yatra, Prime Minister Prachanda assured that these valuable inputs will be carefully considered and gradually incorporated into the next year's policy, programme, and budget. The response aims to address concerns about rural migration and demonstrates the government's commitment to collaborative development efforts with the opposition party.

In response to MP Kantika Sejuwal's concerns about the neglected development of Karnali, Prime Minister Prachanda acknowledged the historical significance of the region and expressed the government's commitment to rectify past neglect and discrimination.

"Recognizing Karnali's potential in water resources, the government has undertaken efforts to advance private sector and government investment in the hydropower sector. The Lamki-Phukot 400 KV transmission line is under construction and plans for high-capacity transmission lines in Bheri Corridor and Fukot-Humla are in progress. Additionally, the government is preparing for the contract process of the 106 MW Jagdulla hydropower project. Several other power generation projects, including Karnali-Phukot and Mugu Karnali, are being advanced through government companies," said PM Prachanda.

"The government is actively discussing game-changer projects for Karnali Province in the next year's policy, programme, and budget, aiming to provide justice and accelerate development and is committed to acknowledging Sinja as a centre of civilization nationally and internationally," said PM Prachanda.

Prime Minister Prachanda responded to MP Gokarna Bista's concerns about the increasing trend of centralization in various economic sectors under by family groups. Acknowledging the potential risks associated with such concentration, the Prime Minister highlighted the government's commitment to addressing these challenges.

"To mitigate risks, the government has set a total loan limit for individuals or groups in the banking sector. Legal and policy arrangements have been put in place to address issues that may arise when the same entity functions as both a bank and a business. Ongoing policy and legal reforms are focused on ensuring a more balanced and diversified economic landscape," said PM Prachanda.

Addressing MP Kusum Devi Thapa's concerns about Rukum East, the Prime Minister assured that the district's issues would be prioritized in the budget allocation for development of infrastructure. He expressed deep respect for martyrs and clarified that while compensation for martyrs couldn't be measured, relief had been provided, and steps would be taken to facilitate the return of gold deposited in Nepal Bank.

In response to MP Kham Bahadur Garbuja's concerns about the Myagdi district and British Gurkha soldiers, PM Prachanda highlighted progress in the construction of the Beni-Darwang-Dhorpatan road and ongoing negotiations for equal pensions for Gurkha soldiers. Efforts to facilitate the return of descendants of retired British soldiers to Nepal were also emphasized, showcasing the government's commitment to development and recognition.

Responding to MP Kalpana Mia Kusari's inquiry about challenges in capital expenditure for national pride projects, the PM acknowledged past issues related to insufficient resource allocation and land acquisition. To enhance project preparation, a project bank was established in the National Planning Commission, ensuring budget allocation only to well-prepared projects before entering the contract phase.

Recognizing the need for specialized expertise, the government now assigns individuals with specific knowledge and skills in project and contract management to oversee project implementation. Efforts are underway to amend existing Forest and Land Acts, which have impacted development projects.

To address MP Gagan Kumar Thapa's economic concerns, the Prime Minister outlined strategies and initiatives focused on public service delivery, revenue administration, foreign aid mobilization, and controlling illegal trade. The government is finalizing a project implementation facilitation procedure to ensure efficient resource utilization and has amended laws for streamlined budget-making.

In reply to MP Kishore Singh Rathore's concerns, the Prime Minister discussed efforts related to rehabilitating free Kamaiya-Kamalari , irrigation facilities, and wildlife conservation. The National Land Commission is actively resolving land-related issues, and relief fund procedures have been revised for residents in the National Park and Buffer Zone areas.

Clarifying concerns raised by MP Geeta Basnet about the Indian Embassy's approval for direct investment, the government stressed the historical context of small development programmes receiving Indian grants. Projects are selected based on recommendations and prioritization, entering the national budget system through a tripartite agreement.

Lastly, addressing MP Ganesh Parajuli's concerns, the Prime Minister provided detailed response on issues like fake Bhutanese refugees, gold smuggling, the Lalita Niwas case, TikTok ban, timber management, and Nepali software use. The government is actively investigating cases, upholding the rule of law, and promoting the IT sector's growth.

Prime Minister Prachanda also mentioned the tragic incident of Balkumari, Lalitpur, of December 29, 2023 and assured that the government would take appropriate measures after conducting a thorough review of the inquiry report submitted by the commission formed on it.

Responding to inquiries from parliamentarians, PM Prachanda openly acknowledged that he had not yet personally examined the report, emphasizing the significance of a comprehensive assessment before any decisive action is taken.

Krishi Samagri Company Limited
Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu

Invitation For Electronic Bids

For the supply and delivery of Chemical Fertilizer
Contract Identification No: KSCL/U/ICB-161/080/081
(Published Date: FEBRUARY 19, 2024)

1. Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal has annual program towards the cost for the procurement of Supply and Delivery of Chemical Fertilizer, Contract Identification No: KSCL/U/ICB-161/080/081 and intends to apply part of the funds to cover eligible payments under the contract. Bidding is open to all eligible Bidders from all countries.
2. Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the procurement of Supply and Delivery of Chemical Fertilizer as mentioned below, ***under International competitive bidding*** – **Single Stage Two Envelope *procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations.*** The fertilizer must be delivered at CIP Nepal basis (Biratnagar, Birgunj and Bhairahawa KSCL warehouses) with insurance up to the final destination as mentioned in the bid document.

Invitation for Bid No	Commodity	Quantity	Cost of the bid document (NRs)	Required bid Security (USD)
KSCL/U/ICB-161/080/081	UREA 46-0-0	30,000±2% MT	20,000	3,48,000.00

3. Under the Single Stage, Two Envelope Procedure, Bidders are required to submit simultaneously two separate sealed envelopes, one containing (i) the Technical Bid and the other (ii) the Price Bid, both in turn enclosed in one sealed envelope as per the provision of ITB 23 of the Bidding Document.
4. Eligible Bidders may obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the office of Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal (Tel: 977-01- 5274819, Email: aicl.nepal@gmail.com) or may visit KSCL's website: http://kscl.gov.np
5. A complete *set* of Bidding Documents may be downloaded from PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders, submitting their bid electronically should deposit the cost of bidding document as mentioned above in the account as specified below. Purchased bid document will be valid only for specified Principal Supplier.
Information to deposit the cost of bidding document in Bank:
Name of Office: Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu.
Current Account of Nepal Investment Mega Bank Ltd. Kalimati with account No. 01701030001922.
6. Pre-bid meeting shall be held at Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu, Nepal at 14:00 hours, March 19, 2024.
7. Electronic bids must be submitted to the office Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu through PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp on or before 13:00 hours on APRIL 05, 2024. Bids or any part thereof received after this deadline will be rejected.
8. The bids will be opened in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend at 14:00 hours on APRIL 05, 2024 at the office of Krishi Samagri Company Limited (KSCL), Head Office, Kuleshwor, Kathmandu. Bids must be valid for a minimum period of 21 days from the date of bid opening and must be accompanied by scanned copy of the bid security in pdf format, amounting as mentioned above, which shall be valid for 120 days from the date of opening of the bid (i.e. August 02, 2024)
9. If the last date of purchasing and /or submission falls on a government holiday, then the next working day shall be considered as the last date. In such case the validity period of the bid security shall remain the same as specified for the original last date of bid submission.

Rohini Rana comes up with another cook book

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18



Rohini Rana has come up with another cooking book titled 'The Nepal Cook Book'.

The book was recently unveiled amid a programme in Kathmandu, delving into the culinary traditions of various ethnic groups from the Himalayas to the Tarai region.

This marks Rana's second venture into Nepali gastronomy, following her previous work, 'The Rana Cook Book', which delved into Darwariya cuisine.

'The Nepal Cook Book' contains a combination of 108 delicious dishes from various ethnic communities.

It has been made attractive by the pictures of costumes and ornaments reflecting the characteristics of the respective communities.

The book launch ceremony saw esteemed figures such as Chief of Army Staff Prabhu Ram Sharma, former Chief of Army Gaurav Shamsher Jung Bahadur Rana, tourism entrepreneur Ambika Shrestha, CNN hero Pushpa Basnet, Agni Group's Sujan Shrestha Vaidya, Mansi Aggarwal, and the author herself came together for the special occasion.

On that occasion, Army Chief Sharma said that Nepal's prosperity lies in various varieties and said that among them, the book written about important food has become another important link to introduce Nepal to the world community.

Gaurav Samsher Rana, the husband of the author, said that the book was prepared to introduce Nepal to the world community.

Author Rana informed that the food of the communities along with their utensils and ornaments have been combined in the book to highlight the characteristics of cooking in Nepal. The book is published by Penguin Publishing of India.

Kala Sereng's 'Kalaka Antaraman' released



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Poet and lyricist Kala Sereng's collection of poetry and songs, titled 'Kalaka Antaraman', was released amid a programme held in the capital on Saturday.

The Chancellor of Nepal Academy, Bhupal Rai, unveiled the book.

This marks Sereng's debut publication after spending 15 years in Hong Kong.

The book comprises 114 pieces, weaving themes that revolve around the memories of her homeland.

Sereng's verses paint vivid imagery of Nepal's lush forests, quaint village dwellings, the majestic Mount Everest, and the profound sentiments of love and attachment nurtured by ancestors and parents.

Chancellor Rai lauded the energy shown in Sereng's poetry, emphasising the transformative power of art and literature within a nation.

Sereng expressed her intentions of encapsulating her journey and emotions through her poetic compositions.

She said that her writings were born from genuine emotion rather than scholarly theory or historical precedence.

Similarly, a music video of Sereng's 'Atitaka Yaadharu' composed by music composer BB Anuragi was released in the programme.

Famous singer Anju Pant has lent her voice to the song. The music video covers the rural life of Likhu Rural Municipality Ward-9 of Okhaldhunga.

The lifestyle of a traditional farming family is presented in the music video.

Sereng and her husband, CM Sunuwar, are featured in the music video.

CM Sunuwar Wambu is also the actor in the movie 'Sumnima' based on Rai culture.

Taylor Swift donates $100,000



AP
Kansas City, Feb. 18

Taylor Swift donated $100,000 to the family of Lisa Lopez-Galvan, the woman killed in the shooting at the Kansas City Chiefs' Super Bowl victory parade.

Two $50,000 donations were posted Friday under the singer's name on a GoFundMe page. Swift's representative confirmed the donations to Variety, the trade publication reported, and The Associated Press independently verified the posts.

"Sending my deepest sympathies and condolences in the wake of your devastating loss. With love, Taylor Swift," read the messages accompanying the posts.

Lopez-Galvan, 43, was shot Wednesday as she celebrated the Chiefs' Super Bowl win with her husband, young adult son and hundreds of thousands of other fans at the city's Union Station. Lopez-Galvan hosted "Taste of Tejano" on local radio station KKFI-FM, as Lisa G. The mother of two had deep roots in Kansas City, and was one of the few Latina DJs in the area. "She was an amazing mother, wife, daughter, sister, aunt, cousin, and friend to so many.

We ask that you continue to keep her family in your prayers as we grieve the loss of her life," the GoFundMe description reads. The fundraised had amassed over $200,000 as of Friday morning.

Twenty-two others, half of whom were under 16, were wounded in the shooting. Investigators are still trying to identify who is responsible, but say a dispute may have led to the shooting. Police have two juveniles in custody and are trying to determine whether others were involved.

Swift, who is dating Chiefs tight end Travis Kelce and attended Sunday's Super Bowl, was not at Wednesday's parade. She's currently performing a series of shows in Melbourne, Australia, as part of her Eras tour.

The Chiefs said all players, coaches, staffers and their families were safe and accounted for after the shooting.

George Santos sues Jimmy Kimmel



AP
New York, Feb. 18

Former U.S. Rep. George Santos alleged in a lawsuit filed Saturday that late-night host Jimmy Kimmel deceived him into making videos on the Cameo app that were used to ridicule the disgraced New York Republican on the show.

The lawsuit filed in U.S. district court for the southern district of New York names Kimmel, ABC and Walt Disney Co. as defendants. A Disney representative listed as a media contact for the Jimmy Kimmel Live! show didn't immediately respond to an email from The Associated Press seeking comment.

Santos, who was expelled from the House of Representatives last year after being charged with multiple counts of fraud and stealing from donors, is suing over alleged copyright infringement, fraudulent inducement, breach of contract and unjust enrichment.

Kimmel misrepresented himself to induce Santos to create personalized videos "capitalizing on and ridiculing" his "gregarious personality," the lawsuit alleges.

Through Cameo, Santos received requests from individuals and businesses seeking personalized video messages. Unbeknownst to Santos, Kimmel submitted at least 14 requests that used phony names and narratives, according to the complaint.

Starting in December the videos were played on a segment, " Will Santos Say It? " the suit says.

In one of the clips, Santos offers congratulations to the purported winner of a beef-eating contest, calling the feat of consuming 6 pounds (2.7 kilograms) of loose ground beef in under 30 minutes "amazing and impressive."

"Frankly, Kimmel's fake requests were funny, but what he did was clear violation of copyright law," Robert Fantone, an attorney for Santos, said in an email.

Santos is seeking statutory damages totaling $750,000 for the five videos he created that were played on the show and various social media platforms. He also asks for other damages to be determined at trial.

The ex-lawmaker faces a slew of criminal charges, including allegations that he defrauded campaign donors, lied to Congress about his wealth, received unemployment benefits while employed and used campaign contributions to pay for personal expenses like designer clothing. He also is alleged to have made unauthorized charges on credit cards belonging to some of his donors.

Santos pleaded not guilty to a revised indictment in October.

On Tuesday, Democrat Tom Suozzi won a special election for Santos' former seat.

BENISHA IS SET TO DEBUT IN HINDI LANGUAGE FILM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Actress Benisha Hamali is all set to do a Hindi language film.

She announced her venture into Hindi cinema through Facebook recently.

Taking to the social networking site Facebook, she uploaded photos hinting at her upcoming project, including one alongside Indian actor Godaan Kumar, known for his roles in popular films like 'Dhadak', 'Laal Kaptaan', 'The Last Show', and others.

Hamal wrote, "Months of working on voice modulation, diction, and flow, I am all set for my first Hindi language movie. Wish me luck."

She has also shared a picture with other actors of the film.

In the picture, it can be seen that they reached Panchchuli in Uttarakhand, hinting at the shooting location of the film.

Hamal, who commenced her acting journey with 'Swar', is gearing up for the release of her upcoming film 'Upaahar' along with Rekha Thapa and Pooja Sharma on March 8.

Her recent release includes the blockbuster Nepali film 'Chakkapanja 4'.



PHOTO: BENISHA'S FACEBOOK

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Your social network is ready to offer you plenty of exciting opportunities today. However, you might struggle to keep up. While the delicate Moon in your cozy 4th house aligns with practical Saturn in your contemplation sector.

Taurus: Talking about a risky goal could be difficult at this time. You want it, and yet you don't -- you're conflicted. While the emotional Moon in your communication zone leans on discerning Saturn in your social sector.

Gemini: You could be inspired by an exciting idea at any point throughout your day, but be careful! As the nervous Moon in your finance zone grumbles at charismatic Venus and ambitious Mars in your philosophical 9th house.

Cancer: You may want to get some things off your chest ASAP, but it's possible that the idea of inviting your friends into your personal business isn't appealing. When the passionate Moon in your sign looks to structured Saturn in your 9th House of Beliefs.

Leo: Getting to know someone new could be exciting for you. However, you might also worry that things are moving too quickly. While the personal Moon in your 12th House of Secrets collaborates with restrained Saturn in your intimacy zone.

Virgo: Your present work could be genuinely engrossing for you. Unfortunately, as the clingy Moon in your 11th House of Friendship conflicts with ecstatic Venus and motivated Mars in your productive 6th house, your social life might be feeling the strain of your absence.

Libra: Choosing between work and play could be a struggle at the moment. Although you can see a glimpse of the rewards that you'll eventually achieve if you keep applying yourself.

Scorpio: Going out and having an adventure might seem like the right thing to do at present. You potentially feel obligated to keep up with your peers' expectations. On the other hand.

Sagittarius: Throwing yourself into a stimulating conversation is possible today. Unfortunately, as the impulsive Moon in your intimacy zone aggravates bold Mars in your communication sector.

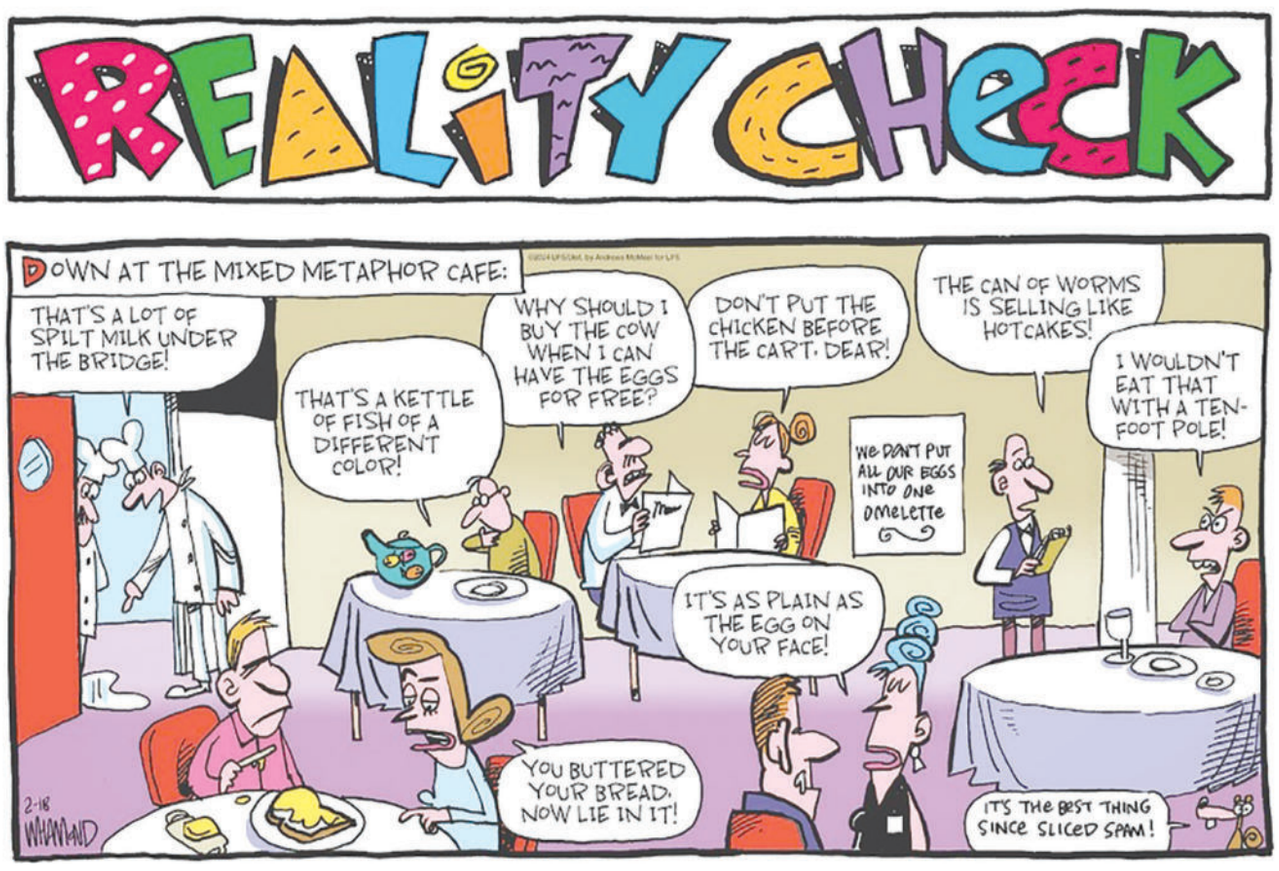
Capricorn: You may currently view your financial prospects with excitement. That said, an unenthusiastic reaction from a loved one could dampen your joy. As the moody Moon in your partnership zone.

Aquarius: You're capable of getting things done with a practical approach. Even so, you might also notice the potential for using charm to cut in line. While the devoted Moon in your responsible 6th house encourages.

Pisces: Finding the right balance in your communications could now require a careful approach. Are you in a situation where you need to convey an impression of seriousness to others? Regardless, a thoughtfully chosen personal story.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Jaiswal double ton headlines India's record 434-run win over England

AP
Rajkot, Feb. 18

Yashasvi Jaiswal became only the third Indian batsman to score consecutive test double hundreds as India completed a record 434-run win against England in the third test on Sunday.

Jaiswal was 214 not out – following on from his 209 in Visakhapatnam – as India declared at 430-4 (98 overs) in its second innings, thus setting the touring side an improbable 557 runs for victory.

England was then routed for 122 runs (39.4 overs) in just over one session, falling to its heaviest test defeat (by runs) since World War II.

Ravindra Jadeja picked up 5-41 to bowl India to what seemed an unlikely day four win, as the hosts took a 2-1 lead in the five-test series. India won the second test by 106 runs after England beat the hosts by 28 runs in the opener.

It was India's biggest test win by runs. Its previous best came in a 372-run victory over New Zealand at Mumbai in 2021.

Post lunch, Jaiswal followed in the footsteps of Vinod Kambli (1993) and Virat Kohli (2017) as he scored a magnificent double hundred off 231 balls.

He added 172 runs off only 158 balls with Sarfaraz Khan, who scored a second consecutive half-century in his debut match.

It was an exceptional hitting performance from the two young batters as India scored 116 runs in just 16 overs at more than seven runs per over.

Jaiswal smashed five more sixes – including a hat trick off James Anderson – taking his innings tally to 12. It was the most sixes hit by an Indian batter in a test innings. For his part, Khan hit three sixes, bringing up his half-century off 65 balls. He finished with 68 not out off 72 balls.

It was a complete change of gears from the morning session when India scored 118 runs in 31 overs. Shubman Gill was run out for 91, while night watchman Kuldeep Yadav had scored 27 runs, as India reached 314-4 at lunch.



PHOTO: AP

India's Yashasvi Jaiswal celebrates his double century on the fourth day of the third cricket test match against England in Rajkot, India, Sunday.

Jaiswal, who had retired hurt in the evening of day three after scoring 104 runs, returned thereafter to plunder the English bowling attack. At 22 years and 52 days, he became the third youngest batter after Kambli (21 years 54 days) and Australia's Don Bradman (21 years 318 days) to score consecutive test double hundreds.

Faced with a monstrous target, England collapsed under the weight of expectation. It was down to 28-4 in 11.1 overs, and then 50-7 in 24.4 overs.

It went to tea at 18-2 from 8.2 overs – first innings' centurion Ben Duckett was run out following a mix up, while his partner Zack Crawley was out lbw to Jasprit Bumrah (1-18).

To make matters worse for England, Ravichandran Ashwin returned to take the field after tea. The off-spinner, who had claimed his 500th test wicket on day two, had flown home to Chennai thereafter for a family medical emergency. He returned to Rajkot on the morning of day four.

Jadeja then wreaked havoc after the final break of the day's play. First, he sent Ollie Pope back for three, out caught at slip, and then trapped Jonny Bairstow lbw for four in consecutive overs.

Joe Root and Ben Stokes added 22 runs, but the fight had gone from England. Jadeja trapped Root lbw for seven in the 22nd over, and then Kuldeep Yadav dismissed Stokes in the same manner six balls later.

Stokes made 15 runs. Yadav made it seven-down as Rehan Ahmed skied a catch to long on for a five-ball duck.

Mark Wood and Tom Hartley threw their bats around to add a few runs to England's total, taking it across 100.

Hartley scored 16, before Ashwin bowled him, finishing with 1-19 from six overs. Jadeja then sealed India's win as Wood was caught at long off, securing the double of a five-wicket haul and scoring a century in the same test for a second time in his career.

It was England's second biggest defeat by runs in test cricket after losing by 562 runs against Australia in 1934.

New 'Nepal A' team loses first match against Canada XI



PHOTO: CAN

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 18

Introducing the 16-men squad to represent Nepal's A team, on February 14, the Cricket Association of Nepal (CAN), a day later on February 15, revealed a three ODI series of the new team with Canada's first team.

Playing the first of the three ODIs against Canada XI at the Upper Mulpani International Cricket Ground on Sunday, the second-tier national team started its campaign with a loss.

Canada, a team desperate for a win after losing all three matches in the series against Nepal's senior team recently, defeated Nepal A by four wickets.

Stepping on the field to bat first, Nepal lost its first wicket in the eighth over as Arjun Kumal (4 off 14) fell victim to Canada's captain Saad Bin Zafar. Mayan Yadav followed Kumal in the 15th over after adding 35 off 56 deliveries.

Captain Binod Bhandari (5 off 11), who was making a comeback into the national jersey after a long gap, departed early as he was struck leg before by Saad in the 18th over.

Danger-looking Rashid Khan was Saad's third wicket in the inning as he bowled Khan in the 34th over. Till then, Khan (40 off 66), partnering with Sundeep Jora and Kiran Thagunna, took the team to 134/5.

Sundeep departed in the 24th, contributing 14 off 25, while Thagunna added 25 runs before returning to the dugout in the 35th.

Basir Ahamad, who came in at eight, was the lifesaver for Nepal as his half-century propelled Nepal to a decent total of 216 runs. With three fours and a six, Basir reached his half-century in the final ball of the first inning facing his 55th delivery. Nepal lost eight wickets to Canada.

Ishwarjot Sohi bagged two wickets while Dilon Heyliger, Harsh Thaker and Shahid Ahamdzai took one each for Canada.

Canada, on the other hand, lost six wickets and chased the target in the final over with three balls remaining. Navneet Dhaliwal saved Canada in the middle overs and Nikhil Dutta took the team to the win in the final overs.

Dhaliwal departed at 80 off 76 balls while Dutta stayed not out at 67 runs in 115 deliveries. Dutta was supported by Shreyas Movva as he stayed not out at 23 off 27.

While captain Saad contributed 23 off 43 in the middle order, the top-three batsmen and Harsh Thaker did not score in double figures.

Shahab Alam bagged two wickets, missing a hattrick, while Pratish GC, Rashid Khan, Sagar Dhakal and Basir Ahamad claimed one wicket each for Nepal.

Nepal A and Canada will play the second of the 3 ODIs on February 20 and the last one on February 22.

SNIPPETS

Juve hand Inter nine-point lead

Rome (AFP): Juventus trail Serie A leaders Inter Milan by nine points after a 2-2 at relegation-threatened Verona, while a 1-1 draw with Genoa left champions Napoli deep in crisis. Massimiliano Allegri's side had their league title hopes further damaged following an entertaining encounter in which Adrien Rabiot saved Juve from losing a third consecutive match. France midfielder Rabiot rifled home second-placed Juve's leveller nine minutes after the break, moments after Tijjani Noslin had put hosts Verona ahead for the second time in the match. Michael Folorunsho, whose touch led to Noslin's goal, had smashed Marco Baroni's team into the lead early on with a stunning volley only for Dusan Vlahovic to equalise from the penalty spot in the 28th minute.

Leverkusen go eight clear

Berlin (AFP): Goals from Jeremie Frimpong and Amine Adli earned Leverkusen a 2-1 win at Heidenheim on Saturday, sending Xabi Alonso's Bundesliga leaders eight points clear of Bayern Munich in second. Leverkusen's win extended their unbeaten run to 32 games in all competitions this season, equalling the record set by Hansi Flick's Bayern across the 2019-20 and 2020-21 seasons. Frustrated by the resolute hosts early, Leverkusen eventually broke through right before half-time when Frimpong's deflected shot found the net. Midfield maestro Florian Wirtz hit the crossbar late but helped seal the result shortly after, laying on a perfect pass for Adli to round the goalkeeper and score. Heidenheim's Tim Kleindienst headed in a goal with three minutes remaining, the first time Leverkusen had conceded in six hours in the league.

Mbappe scores as sub

Paris (AFP) – Kylian Mbappe came off the bench and scored a penalty as Paris Saint-Germain beat Nantes 2-0 on Saturday after the France captain informed the club this week he plans to leave at the end of the season. Lucas Hernandez's deflected strike broke the deadlock on the hour at the Stade de la Beaujoire before Mbappe made sure of the points after he was fouled inside the area. PSG stretched their lead at the top of Ligue 1 to 14 points with a record-extending 12th title surely now a formality after Nice suffered a fifth loss in nine games Friday.

Salah scores in Liverpool return

AFP
London, Feb. 18

Mohamed Salah returned with a goal as Premier League leaders Liverpool routed Brentford 4-1 despite a rash of injuries, while Manchester City's title defence was damaged by a 1-1 draw against Chelsea on Saturday.

Arsenal demolished Burnley 5-0 to keep the pressure on Liverpool, who are two points above the second-placed Gunners and four-ahead of third placed City.

Salah came off the bench to replace the injured Diogo Jota in his first Liverpool appearance since their win over Newcastle on New Year's Day.

Having returned from the hamstring injury he sustained on Egypt duty at the Africa Cup of Nations, Salah made up for lost time with his first goal for the Reds since the Newcastle game.

The 31-year-old's 19th goal in all competitions this term put Liverpool on course for a sixth win in their last seven league games.

The much-maligned Darwin Nunez had given Jurgen Klopp's side the lead with a sublime chip late in the first half at the Gtech Community Stadium.

Alexis Mac Allister doubled Liverpool's advantage after the interval with just his second goal this season.

Ivan Toney got one back for Brentford, but Cody Gakpo netted in the closing stages.

While the victory was valuable for Klopp, it came with a downside as first-half injuries to Nunez, Jota and Curtis Jones added to Liverpool's increasingly packed treatment room.

"Mo played the first game for weeks. He could have had a hat-trick. The goal he scored was absolutely outstanding," Klopp said. "It would be helpful if we had a bit more than one player for each position. But that's the situation and we cannot change it."

Manchester City's attempt to win an unprecedented fourth successive title is under threat after a disappointing result at the Etihad Stadium.

Chelsea took the lead in the 41st minute as former City winger Raheem Sterling took Nicolas Jackson's pass and curled his shot into the far corner from 12 yards.

City laid siege to the Chelsea goal and finally drew level in the 83rd minute when Rodri's shot deflected in off Trevoh Chalobah.

Pep Guardiola's men, who have a game in hand on Liverpool, preserved their long unbeaten home league run, but failing to win for the first time in 12 games in all competitions was a significant setback.

At Turf Moor, Arsenal made it five consecutive wins with another display of their goal power.

Mikel Arteta's side have beaten Liverpool and won 6-0 at West Ham in their most notable results since a revitalising warm-weather training camp in Dubai.

And they were too hot for second-bottom Burnley to handle from the fourth minute when Martin Odegaard drilled home from Gabriel Martinelli's pass.

Bukayo Saka netted with a 41st-minute penalty awarded for Lorenz Assignon's foul on Leandro Trossard.

Saka struck again two minutes after half-time, rifling into the top corner from Odegaard's pass as the England winger made it six goals in his last four games.

Trossard got the fourth from close range in the 66th minute and Kai Havertz converted Jakub Kiwior's pass with 12 minutes left.

Tottenham's top four bid suffered a blow as Joao Gomes struck twice in Wolves' surprise 2-1 win in north London.

Aston Villa took advantage of Tottenham's stumble to climb back into fourth place with a 2-1 win at Fulham thanks to Ollie Watkins' brace. Nottingham Forest beat West Ham 2-0 at the City Ground in a major boost to their survival hopes.

Newcastle manager Eddie Howe avoided defeat against his former club Bournemouth in a 2-2 draw at St James' Park.

Lewandowski snatches Barca win

AFP
Barcelona, Feb. 18

Robert Lewandowski snatched champions Barcelona an unconvincing 2-1 win over lowly Celta Vigo with a brace to leave them third in La Liga on Saturday.

Xavi Hernandez's side trail leaders Real Madrid by seven points.

Atletico Madrid, fourth, thrashed Las Palmas 5-0 earlier on and trail Barcelona by three points.

The Catalans needed a stoppage-time penalty converted by Lewandowski at the second attempt to find a way past a Celta Vigo side battling relegation, down in 17th place. Lewandowski slammed the visitors ahead at Balaidos before half-time but Iago Aspas levelled for Rafa Benitez's Celta early in the second half.

Barcelona tamely struggled to find a way through before being gifted a late spot-kick for a clumsy foul on Lamine Yamal, which Lewandowski dispatched for his 12th goal of the season.

Lewandowski's first penalty attempt was saved by Vicente Guaita but as the goalkeeper was off his line, the striker was given another chance and he converted.

The Catalans are unbeaten in four matches since Xavi said he would depart at the end of the season.

Celta sit three points above the relegation zone after Cadiz, 18th, lost 2-0 at Osasuna earlier on. Valencia, eighth, dominated Sevilla but could not find the breakthrough in a 0-0 draw.

Earlier Atletico Madrid hammered Las Palmas despite resting key forward Antoine Griezmann.

Marcos Llorente and Angel Correa struck twice each and Memphis Depay was also on target as Diego Simeone's side strolled to victory.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:38 am, Sunset at 5:57 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly to generally cloudy in Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly regions of the country and Partly cloudy to mainly fair rest of the country. Light rain is likely to occur at a few places Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of hilly region of the country. Chances of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and at one or two places of high hilly and mountainous regions of the country.

Expected Temp.: 21-23 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	24.3	8.4	0.0
Dadeldhura	18.4	6.0	0.0
Dhangadi	24.9	10.3	0.0
Birendranagar	24.3	8.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	25.7	10.0	0.0
Jumla	20.0	-1.9	0.0
Ghorahi	23.5	10.0	0.0
Pokhara	23.1	12.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.0	10.0	0.0
Simara	26.1	9.0	0.0
Kathmandu	22.1	6.3	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.9	8.3	0.0
Taplejung	17.8	9.5	0.0
Dhankuta	22.4	10.4	0.0
Biratnagar	26.3	9.5	0.0
Jomsom	12.0	-1.5	0.0*
Dharan	25.5	13.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.5	8.5	0.0*
Janakpur	28.5	9.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.5	3.0	1.2*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 19, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.53	Rs. 133.13
Euro	1	Rs. 142.81	Rs. 143.46
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.99	Rs. 167.74
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.49	Rs. 151.17
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.57	Rs. 86.96
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.28	Rs. 98.72
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.46	Rs. 98.90
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.82	Rs. 8.86
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.34	Rs. 35.50
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.68	Rs. 3.70
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.25
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.72	Rs. 27.85
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.95	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.76
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.16	Rs. 19.25
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.02
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.35	Rs. 432.30
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.54	Rs. 353.13

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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Democracy Day

SPECIAL

2024 February 19, Monday | Fagun 7, 2080

Transformative Shift In Democratic Movement



Dr. Narad Bharadwaj

A great transformative shift appears to have started deep down in the fragmented and polarised core of societies. It is difficult to predict when the violent shakeup will take place, but the world has arrived at the turning point of a tectonic transformation of human society.

In an article titled 'Democracy at a Turning Point: A Treatise on Democratic Limits of Democracy', Luka Nikolic and Igor Milic have argued that 'democracy can only exist as a promise to come. Its fatal attraction lies in this deceptive nature'. From the surface, their remark sounds cynical, but if we go deeper into the paradoxes of democracy they have tried to address, what the authors have said rings true.

Democracy is considered the best form of governance that human civilization has experienced in its history. It is the best because, in a democracy, those who are privileged to rule must be elected by the people. Democracy is based on the widest possible consensus as expressed by the majority; it allows space for the people to deliberate on social issues and ensures that people can enjoy the broad spectrum of rights attached to individual liberty.

As a form of governance, democracy has many characteristic features, the most outstanding of which is popular sovereignty. Similarly, equality before the law, protection of the rights and dignity of citizens, periodic and regular elections, and, most importantly, a system of accountability place it on a higher pedestal among other contemporary forms of governance.

Over the past few decades, however, democracy has been reduced to a ritual rather than a robust system legitimised by popular endorsement, despite the above-stated progressive provisions. Under the garb of democracy, politics has been fragmented into many extreme polarities, ranging from far left, far right, conservative, and neo-conservative to liberal and neo-liberal denominations. These forces vie for power and do not hesitate to go to any length to compromise principles and values that nurture and nourish democracy as a system of governance. At present, elections are projected as the quintessential element of democracy, and winning them through fair or foul means is the most credible eligibility for running the affairs of the state.

Democracy is a participatory system, but it is fast turning into a playing field for an exclusive class of political nouveau riches to score an advantage by juggling through electoral tricks. However, as former Brazilian President Fernando Cardoso has said, "Democracy is not just a question of having a vote. It consists of strengthening each citizen's possibility and capacity to participate in the deliberations involved in the life of society.".

Democracy is a system of governance, not in the sense of controlling, limiting, and restricting new ideas, the mobility of the people, the advancement and diffusion of knowledge, or the people's quest for a prosperous life. It is a philosophy of self-governance to optimise the creative potentials of society by allowing its individual members a free framework for unleashing their potentials so that the whole society enjoys liberty, equality, and access to opportunities.

Today, the above values ascribed to democracy are no longer functional. There is a consensus among intellectuals and political scientists that the western model of democracy is in retreat. Every country in the democratic world is in crisis. Elected leaders are showing a penchant for using the electoral majority as a licence for achieving power and clinging to it perpetually. The successive electoral victories achieved through rigging or manipulation by military rulers of some South Asian, East Asian, Latin American, and African countries have been used to perpetuate military dictatorships and ride roughshod over the people, stifling society's aspirations for political freedom and the rule of law.

Today, even those countries that boast themselves of being the oldest and largest democracies are found mired in intractable social contradictions, economic disparities, polarisation of politics, and fragmentation of society. We find leaders of these countries forming populist agendas around inflammable religious, ethnic, external, or domestic threats, perceived or real. Political parties are shedding ethical standards and putting themselves in survival mode, indulging in misrepresentation of facts, restrictions on free ideas, and manipulation of media outlets to serve their narrow interests. Today, the mass media is so polarised that it is difficult to form an opinion and make an informed decision on the basis of an independent source of information.

James Madison once said, 'The advancement and diffusion of knowledge is the true guardian of democracy'. But it works just the opposite in the present-day global context. Different media portals depict events of war, social unrest, international humanitarian crime, and genocide differently. What is racialism for Africans is not so for Americans; what is genocide in Ukraine is not so in Israel; what is ethnic cleansing in the case of Rohingya Muslims is not so in the case of Palestinians or Syrians. Today, fabrication, lies, and misleading information are debasing the ethical standard of the media and making people delusional.

As ideological polarisation and fragmentation proliferate, different versions of democracy have emerged in the world. The western democracy that came into existence with the French Revolution of 1789 appears to have completed its life cycle as a tool for achieving liberty, equality, and fraternity. Western democracy contributed to expanding the intellectual universe of human society for over 235 years but could not achieve much in the field of ensuring equality, inclusion, and justice. This is the reason why it appears to be facing the risk of being pushed into irrelevance.

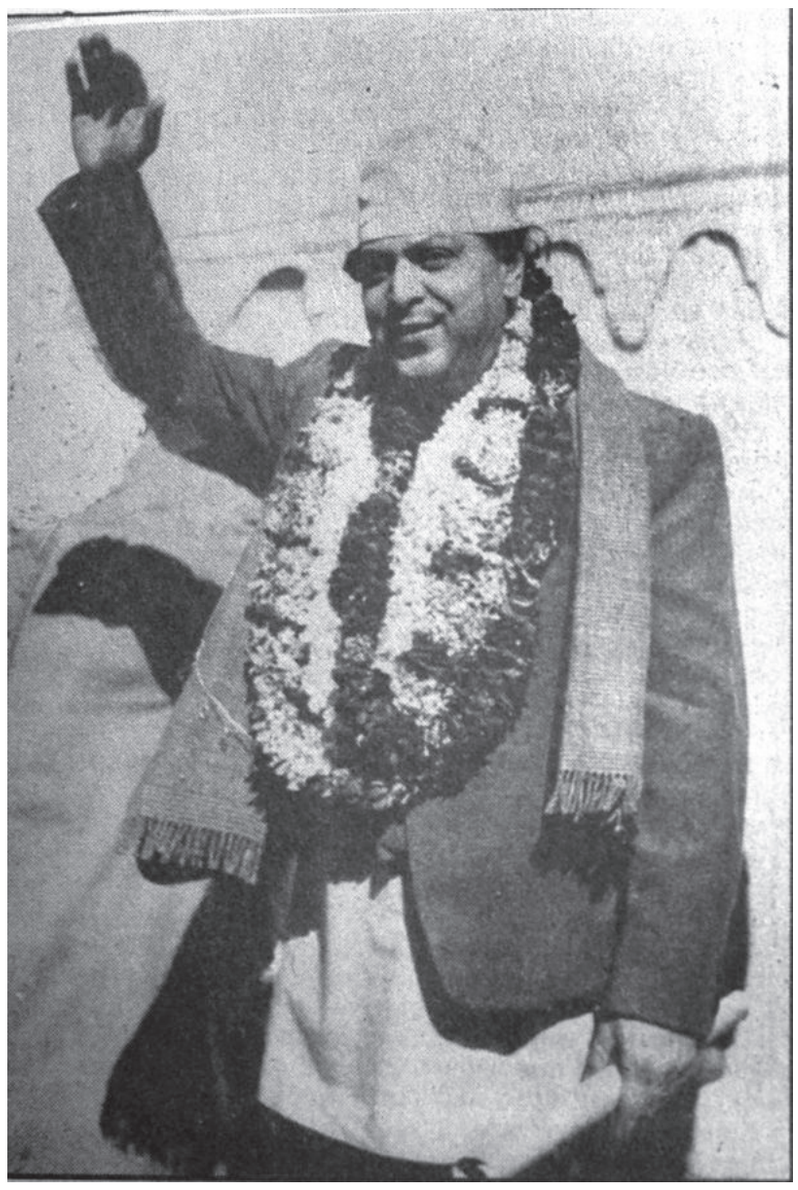
In conclusion, the parliamentary democracy institutionalised by the 1789 revolution has reached the point of stagnation. Despite lofty rhetoric about liberty, equality, and fraternity, it could not usher in the type of social transformation it had promised in its heydays through revolutions of different hues and nametags.

Today, global society appears restless in the quest for an alternative version of democracy that is better attuned to human aspirations for change and progress.

A great transformative shift appears to have started deep down in the fragmented and polarised core of societies. It is difficult to predict when the violent shakeup will take place, but the world has arrived at the turning point of a tectonic transformation of human society.

(Bharadwaj is a former ambassador and former chairperson of Gorkhapatra Corporation. bharadwajnarad@gmail.com)





Overcoming Structural Challenges of Democracy



Ritu Raj Subedi

Political actors must adhere to constitutional norms, values, and conduct, thereby securing people's confidence in their capacity to safeguard a nation's sovereignty and attain the inclusive economic growth necessary for democratic order, peace, and prosperity in the country.

One of the world's oldest nations, Nepal boasts a tradition of ancient enlightenment and modern democratic evolution. The blend of ancientry and modernity puts the Himalayan nation in a unique position, distinct from other nations. The term 'democracy' is generally understood as the rule of people, either through their direct participation in the political process and governance affairs or by sending their representatives to conduct these tasks. Though the very word might not have been used, its spirit was embraced in ancient times in Nepal.

Even before the ancient city-state of Athens started to use the word 'democracy,' it had already been adopted and implemented in the East. In the ancient kingdom of Bideh, which was located in present-day Janakpur in the south of Nepal, King Janak applied the concept of 'philosopher king' that was theorised by Plato many centuries later. The notion was the cornerstone of Greek philosophers ideal state, which is akin to the 'utopia' of pre-Marxist philosophers and Marx's vision of classless society.

Critical discourse

According to Plato, rulers, like philosophers, must possess knowledge, intelligence, wisdom, training, and basic skills to govern the state, thereby ensuring the welfare of the people. King Janak had emulated these virtues and conducted the shastrartha (critical discourse), in which rishis (sages) rigorously deliberated on the fundamental elements of the universe and human life—its existence, aim, knowledge, morality, and duties of the state. People of all walks of life joined this debate. It is a mode of consultation applied to resolve conflict and ensure justice for the victims. It is a dharma-based justice system that goes beyond a legalistic and logic-guided approach. The concept of dan to the poor and public education had received greater prominence in society. The gist of the idea, churned out by the assembly of savants, served as the guideline for the king to establish relations with the people and handle the affairs of the state.

Nepalis have imbibed the tradition of enlightenment of the Vedas, Janak, and Buddha, which offer theoretical and practical insight into comprehending and embracing the ideas of democracy, governance, justice, and public morality. This might sound strange for the West, which claims as if 'democracy' exclusively belongs to it. The age-old enlightenment tradition has been embedded in the collective consciousness of Nepalis. This is a reason why they are not afraid of fighting for democracy, civil liberties, equality, and justice, as reflected in various movements, uprisings, and revolutions. Nepalis have not tolerated autocracies of different hues. During peacetime, they have made rational choices through ballots. The political parties that fail to translate electoral promises into action have been removed from the seat of power.



The 1951 political change, also known as the sat sal ko kranti (revolution that occurred in 2007 B.S.), was the first ever revolution that toppled the Rana Oligarchy and established multiparty democracy. The epoch-making political change transformed the people from raitis (subjects) to citizens. The Nepali people, for the first time, enjoyed the taste of freedom, breaking the shackles that had fettered them for over a century. The new political environment put the country on the path of modernization. Human rights, periodic elections, freedom of the press, and an independent judiciary became the new lexicons of Nepali politics. The opening up to the outer world gave Nepalis exposure to new concepts of modern education, political thought, and technology.

Sat sal ko kranti is considered the foundation as well as the fountain of subsequent political movements waged for equality, autonomy, and dignity for the marginalised people who have been facing structural injustice for centuries. The people's movement of 1990 and the April Uprising of 2006 have proved milestones in further advancing Nepali society. They brought unprecedented changes in terms of an increase in people's awareness, living standards, civic associations, and use of information technology. The rise of social media catapulted society into another phase of the information revolution that connected people and nations through the digital highway. It has changed the way people communicate with and react to others. For all its shortcomings, social media pushed the frontiers of knowledge and broadened the scope of participatory democracy.

Transformation

Nepal's transformation into a federal democratic republic through the new constitution promulgated by the Constituent Assembly in 2015 marks the adoption of a comprehensive and refined form of democracy, with a greater focus on inclusion, gender parity, and the upliftment of disadvantaged social and economic groups. However, our democracy requires fixing scores of structural problems. One chronic malaise is the patriocracy, which has not only polarised the political spectrum but also weakened the key organs of state, resulting in the loss of their credibility and trust. Public institutions must be impersonal and efficient so that they are able to carry out their constitutional duties fairly. The effectiveness and resilience of democracy lie in the competency of the state's institutions to deliver goods and services to citizens without hassle.

People's constant vigilance and ability to make informed choices at the ballot box can play a critical role in institutionalising democracy. However, periodic elections are not enough. Democratisation of leadership as well as the structures of political parties is a must to channel the grassroots' voice into policy and law-making bodies. This necessitates promoting organic intellectuals, impartial media, and civic organisations that have the guts to call a spade a spade. Strong economies, stability, and balanced foreign policy are equally important for democracy to function, thrive, and deepen.

As the country observes Democracy Day today, it is imperative to reflect on the weaknesses and strengths of our democratic polity. Political actors must adhere to constitutional norms, values, and conduct, thereby securing people's confidence in their capacity to safeguard a nation's sovereignty and attain the inclusive economic growth necessary for democratic order, peace, and prosperity in the country.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)



Hurdles To Thriving Democracy



Narayan Upadhyay

Nepal's path to democracy has been marked by success, disappointments, and ongoing challenges and struggles. From the removal of the monarchy to the adoption of a federal, republican, and democratic constitution, Nepal has taken significant steps towards establishing itself as a democratic and pluralist society. It is encouraging to see that the country's inclusive and participatory political system has garnered international praise and recognition; nonetheless, challenges to strengthening hard-earned democracy remain.

We must never forget that a healthy democratic society anticipates good governance, the rule of law, and the protection of human rights. It also aims to encourage and safeguard free expression, the right to live and work, and the freedom to follow any ideology or belief of one's choosing. It also seeks to foster multi-party politics and a pluralistic society in which people can elect their representatives through the ballot.



. Our political leadership's negligence and the lacklustre performance of our judicial system have the potential to destablise our democratic system of governance.



Discrimination

All of our government's efforts and activities must aim at accomplishing the universally accepted principles of democracy, which always serve the best interests of sovereign citizens, who must receive all public services without bias or prejudice. A citizen in a democratic nation should not be the subject of any discrimination in getting government services and enjoying constitutionally guaranteed rights based on their caste, faith, gender, or area, as equal rights are the hallmark of a true democracy. Now, certain individuals and regions feel they are being discriminated against simply because they do not support particular leaders or adhere to the ideologies and diktats of political parties in power, which must not be the case in a democracy.

Several unwarranted events have occurred in our country, endangering democratic norms and values. Political instability, driven by frequent transitions in governments, has led to a growing culture of impunity and corruption. Political leaders' involvement in corrupt practices and abuse of authority, the nexus between corporations, politicians, and bureaucracy, nepotism, and inaction over service delivery are usually identified as important impediments to democratic consolidation. All of these widely publicised events have posed challenging questions: why did leaders and parties work so hard to bring about change in the nation? Were these changes intended to allow them to engage in inappropriate behaviours that undermine democratic achievements?

In recent years, the country has been rocked by major scandals stemming from corrupt acts by politicians, powerful entrepreneurs, and bureaucrats alike. Despite a vociferous demand from the general public, civic society, and the press for the prosecution of corrupt individuals, the law has remained ineffective in dealing with offenders and corrupt individuals who have walked free due to their ties with the powerful.

A lack of good governance and a scarcity of opportunities at home have frustrated both our youth and common folks alike. The rise of new political forces and some groups calling for a return to monarchy are testaments to frustration. A substantial number of frustrated youths and others have left the country, raising concerns about the future well-being of the country.

A country that is now dealing with a major exodus of young people who form a significant workforce cannot carry out economic and productive activities and thus will have a difficult time having good economic status, which is required to build a vibrant democratic nation.

Polarisation

Worse, famous leaders and political parties have frequently failed to deal appropriately with such said situations. Instead of righting their wrongs, they are willing to go to any extent to protect their own interests, further irritating citizens. While influential politicians and decision-makers' apathy towards serving people and the nation's interests is concerning, the polarisation of politics and society has created additional concerns about the future of our hard-won democracy.

Similarly, a lack of strong law enforcement mechanisms to tackle corruption and crime, as well as an ineffective and weaker legal system, have disappointed people who want to see democracy take firm root in the country. A strong and independent judicial system is the last resort for all victims of oppressors and powerful authoritarians. Currently, the entire judiciary is under fire for failing to bring powerful and wealthy offenders to justice. Sometimes those who work within our legal system convey the appearance that they have not protected the system's purity, undercutting the basic idea that the judiciary functions best when it is autonomous. An independent judiciary is one of the foundations of a democratic society. In short, the absence of a strong court weakens the principles, values, and spirit of democracy.

All these unwarranted episodes in the country have encouraged groups of people seeking to restore monarchy in any form, whether constitutional or cultural, by repealing the current constitution, which was enacted by the Constituent Assembly in 2015 to establish Nepal as a democratic federal secular republican state. When the constitution was enacted, it aimed to address the long-standing grievances of marginalised people, end discriminatory practices, offer inclusive governance, and decentralise power to the provincial and municipal levels to empower people at all levels.

Following the constitution's implementation, there were obstacles such as ethnic clashes, territorial disputes, and issues with the devolution of power and resources to provinces and local governments. However, the country has now accomplished many of the objectives specified in the constitution, which has proven to be a vital document. Beside accomplishing several goals, the constitution is significant for including all democratic values in its preamble, which implies that no party can change them without a two-thirds majority in parliament.

No one would deny that if our constitution and democracy fail, it will be due to the irresponsible actions and performances of politicians and their parties, who routinely undermine democratic norms and ideals. Some noteworthy leaders have frequently displayed a predisposition to verbally embrace democratic norms and spirits, but when it comes to acting in the best interests of democratic principles and spirits, they fall short.

Meanwhile, foreign relations experts emphasise that a democratically vibrant country may provide a good example for its neighbours for achieving stability in the region. Though many people applaud Nepal's relatively peaceful transition from a unitary to a federal system of government, others criticise our politicians and parties for failing to maintain balanced relations with its two larger, more powerful neighbours and other countries.

Weak Leadership

Similarly, Nepal's voice in international forums has weakened in recent years as a result of its reckless and weak leadership, which has been inconsistent in taking strong independent positions on topics of international importance. What is more bothersome is that international power centres frequently take advantage of our weaker status to interfere in our internal affairs. Some analysts believe that certain power centres do not want Nepal to be a dynamic, democratic country that empowers its population.

Our democracy faces numerous challenges, despite the fact that it was established through arduous struggles and efforts. Our political leadership's negligence and the lacklustre performance of our judicial system have the potential to destablise our democratic system of governance. Here, the media, civil society, and the general public may act as vital components in exerting pressure on our political leadership and judicial stakeholders to act in accordance with democratic ideals and principles in order to sustain and develop Nepal as a full-fledged democratic society. All stakeholders in democracy must thus embrace democratic ideals in true spirit without seeking self-serving interests, enabling Nepal to achieve good governance, peace, stability, and prosperity, which are prerequisites for a thriving democracy.

(Upadhyay is the former managing editor of this daily.)

Democracy, Development And Desperation



Nanda Lal Tiwari



Political leaders have been blamed for bribes. If the situation does not improve as expected, common people might start believing what the regressive forces have been claiming, which may eventually bring about another setback in democracy.

Democracy Day in Nepal has been observed on Fagun 7, particularly to commemorate the overthrow of the autocratic Rana regime over seven decades ago in 1951 by an armed insurrection coupled with peaceful people's movements. In the last seven decades, the country has witnessed many political turning points, for instance, the imposition of the party-forbidden Panchyat system in 1961, the people's movements that reinstated parliamentary democracy in 1990, the onset of the people's war in 1996 that sought republican set up through the election of a Constituent Assembly to write a new constitution, the people's movement II initiated by the seven-party alliance and the Maoists in 2006 that succeeded in doing away with monarchy by holding the election to the Constituent Assembly in 2008, and the promulgation of the Constitution by the CA in 20015. Democracy as a political system has seen both setbacks and progress over the decades since the 1950s. The imposition of a party-less Panchayat by the monarchy was a setback, whereas the abolition of monarchy and establishment of a republic was a historic progress for democracy.

With the introduction of democracy in 1951, the awareness that people are entitled to choose their rulers by means of franchise took root and grew with the passage of time in the minds of people of all strata across the country. It was this consciousness that propelled people into taking arms or joining the forces in the urban street to do away with monarchy when they knew monarchy had been an obstacle to the smooth growth and functioning of democracy.



With the constitution promulgated by the CA in 2015, an inclusive, participatory democracy has been institutionalised. The oppressed, marginalised communities have been enjoying political inclusion by means of their proportional representation in the state organs and public employment. Unlike in the past, there are public holidays for celebrating traditional festivals of the indigenous peoples and different religions and regions. A public holiday to mark Lhosar of the Tamang, Gurung or Sherpa, Maghi of the Magar and Tharus, Chrismas of the Christian, or Ramajan/Eid ul-Fitra of the Muslim was unthinkable in the past. It is a reality now. Constitutional provisions make it mandatory that women's representation in lawmaking bodies stand at least at 33 per cent. The people who were marginalised as untouchable, the Dalit, have been granted rights at par with any other so-called upper castes, and as a prerogative, a seat in the ward of local levels has been reserved for Dalit women. For some people with an old, conservative, and extreme religious mindset, this new reality has been tough to bear. Those who fail to grasp that man is born equal or that man is the creator of his or her destiny have grievances over this.

If we compare the scale of Nepal's physical infrastructure, including road networks, hospitals, schools, electricity, and communication facilities available today, with that in 1951, when democracy was first introduced, or, let's say, in 2008, when monarchy was abolished, the current status is beyond comparison. There has been unprecedented progress in all spheres of physical infrastructure development. However, if we compare Nepal's development pace with any other country, we may find Nepal lagging far behind in many respects. The point is that the country has failed to keep up with the pace of time with regard to development. The revolution in communication technology as expressed on the internet and social media has enabled even common people across the world to compare their current situation with that of other countries, especially the developed ones. This exposure has given rise to the sense of having fallen far behind in development.

Additionally, the country has not been able to create new job opportunities. The economic revolution that the leaders vowed to bring about after the political revolution, that is, the establishment of a republic, has not taken place. No new industries that could provide decent jobs to young generations have been set up. With the progress in living standards of the people due to remittance, the country has become much more import-reliant now than in the past. Moreover, service delivery has not been as efficient as desired by the people. This has all made people desperate, as seen in the exodus of people to other, rich or developed, countries for jobs, education, and settlement.

It is noteworthy that the incumbent government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has been striving to make service delivery efficient, curb corruption, and resume the state-run industries made redundant in the recent past. Despite intense efforts on the part of the government, the results are not so promising. There is some progress, but this scale of progress does not seem to be likely to do away with the obstacles left by historical anomalies. No doubt, people have started to become optimistic, but large-scale government initiatives for creating job opportunities are needed to sustain this. People's optimism is the positive force, whereas desperation is the negative one. Optimistic people can contribute to government and state efforts, while desperate people simply create barriers. There are efforts by the regressive forces to blame the present polity, the democratic republic, for the present plight of the people. Political leaders have been blamed for bribes. If the situation does not improve as expected, common people might start believing what the regressive forces have been claiming, which may eventually bring about another setback in democracy. Therefore, it is the responsibility of all the democratic political forces in the country to come together to consolidate democracy by ushering in development.

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Where Does Nepali Democracy Stand?



Chandra Dev Bhatta



Rather than correcting ourselves and reflecting upon the realities, many started equating the situation with the failure of democracy, which certainly is not true for the reason that they all can be fixed.

This year, the government has decided to celebrate 'national democracy' day for three days. Yet this is not the first time. Such celebrations, indeed, have been celebrated since 1951, when democracy, which we call modern and liberal, was first introduced in Nepal. Since then, Nepali governments led by political parties of different hues have been celebrating Democracy Day with big fanfare. This author still remembers mishri (a kind of candy) being distributed in the school during the Panchayat period. Interesting as it is, celebrations of this kind certainly depict that there is a certain level of 'commitment' towards democracy, at least with regard to 'celebration'. And over the period of time, those commitments towards celebration alone have also percolated into actions with regard to the democratisation process, which certainly is something of which we can be proud.

There exists a broader sense of "frustration and discontent" in society. While certain aspects are intertwined with the existing political landscape in which democracy operates, others stem from a dearth of opportunities, particularly economic ones, within the nation. In fact, there could be more reasons as well. In that regard, perhaps it will be more appropriate to quote the first sentence of Leo Tolstoy's novel 'Anna Karenina', where he says, Happy families are alike, and every unhappy family is unhappy in its own way'.

Certainly, Nepalis are no different, and they, too, have more than one reason to be unhappy or frustrated, for that matter, and they are anchored in more than one way.

Today, if we talk to those who are in their early 20s, they feel most unsecured and do not see better prospects in this country, even if they are having a good life out here. The collective insecurity, perceived and real, has become the defining moment of this generation, which has been building up for quite some time. Yet little or no attempts were made to look into their concerns, due to which we have reached a point where every third person is waiting to board the next flight abroad. For all the practical reasons, the mass resignation of people from the state and society raises some key questions about the way we have understood and practiced democracy.

Paradoxical as it may be, this is the harsh truth, and if it continues, this may invite what scholars call 'polycrisis', and the permanent nature of such crises would push what is referred to as 'permacrisis'.

Common phenomenon

This is the type of state we have developed over the last couple of decades. Who do we blame for this? Perhaps this should be our collective failure, and there is a need to accept this fact. Although what we have been observing around the world, dissent with democracy, is not only taking place in Nepal, if it is at all taking place, it is being noticed equally in those countries that claimed to be the most democratic ones. That said, democratic backsliding has become a common phenomenon these days. In that regard, at least two factors could be cited as to why such a state of affairs has arisen.

First, over a period of time, democratic processes (elections and other mechanisms) along with the political sphere have been largely captured by certain classes. For the common people, it has always remained what scholars call a 'limited or close access order'. Second, the rise of a new political economy (technology included) and technology-induced globalisation per se factors have brought fundamental changes in society. However, politics somehow could not really address those changes in the way they needed to be looked into. In contrast, we could see three diametrically opposite imaginations vis-à-vis the reality of the time with regard to fixing democracy: political imagination, intellectual imagination, and societal imagination.

Taken together, they have created a huge gap and led to the rise of populism, conservatism, and nationalism. Such a state of affairs has only pitted what we call 'progressive' agendas with 'regressive' ones, and vice versa. We have failed to ascertain what is right and what is wrong. On the contrary, a new way of thinking has been developed: what is good for me will also be good for others as well. This certainly is not true, but, sadly, this is the reality that we live in, and democracy has to grapple with it. Rather than correcting ourselves and reflecting upon the realities, many started equating the situation with the failure of democracy, which certainly is not true for the reason that they all can be fixed.

Democracy provides room for improvement and correction compared to many other political ideas and philosophies, but all of these depend on how we acknowledge the problems and communicate with the people. What is certainly true, however, is that democracy is not having the best of times, not only in Nepal but in many other countries where it has been claimed to have roots. Moreover, democracy, in fact, is pitted between far-rightist and extreme-leftist forces, while mediating forces or ideologies in between are becoming weaker for the reasons mentioned above. Also, the return of geopolitics in the form of geo-economics is also bringing its own momentum for all of us and will certainly have consequences for democracy as well, primarily because they are both forcing countries to defend their interests, not their values. Under such a state of affairs, democracy will only become a means but not an end.

Coming back to Nepal, many people are of the view that Byabastha Badliyo, Tara Awastha Badaliyana. For them, there are fundamental gaps between Byabastha and Awastha, and it is this gap that is resulting in a trust deficit towards democratic systems in more than one way. But they are also untrue, partly because, if we go by the fourth Nepal Living Standard Survey (2022-23), Nepal has achieved significant improvement in its livelihood. The level of poverty has come down, though not as expected. Likewise, individual families living standards have gone up in more than one way. The survey clearly indicates that the Awastha of Nepalis has also changed over the decades.

Striking a balance

But what we have missed here is the fact that it has all happened and its social and other costs. The biggest worry for Nepal is that the country has not been able to strike the right balance between political rights and economic opportunities, due to which people at large are dependent on the outside world for their livelihood. It is remittances that have significantly contributed to reducing poverty and improving people's living standards. But certainly, it cannot be sustainable. Neither would it strengthen democracy in the long run.

We are already bearing the social cost of the current 'improvement in living standards' as more than one quarter of the population lives outside for their livelihood. This is where our democracy stands today.

Perhaps the time has come for all of us to realise that we should not simply reduce democracy to a mere occasion of celebration alone, which will, for sure, not yield much for the common people. We need to create a level playing field so that its dividends can be realised by all. Democracy doesn't need to be defended; what it requires is democrats; that's what we all have to be.

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Parties Must Embrace Good Culture



Ballav Dahal



Political leaders have been blamed for bribes. If the situation does not improve as expected, common people might start believing what the regressive forces have been claiming, which may eventually bring about another setback in democracy.

The nation is marking the 74th National Democracy Day today with great fanfare to commemorate the dawn of democracy with the elimination of the 104-year-old autocratic Rana rule. It was possible for the Nepali people and the political parties, including the Nepali Congress (NC), to make the first people's uprising for democracy a success with their firm determination and untiring efforts. Many freedom fighters had attained martyrdom in the course of their fight for democracy. The Rana oligarchy would not have come to an end without their great sacrifice. Since the NC was instrumental in ushering in democracy, it was able to secure an overwhelming two-thirds majority in the parliamentary elections held in 1959.

But King Mahendra resorted to strangling the hard-won democracy at birth to impose his direct rule, dampening the people's hopes for openness and freedom. He suspended the constitution and dissolved the parliament. He dismissed the cabinet headed by popular leader BP Koirala and imprisoned Koirala and his close associates immediately. Along with that unwanted royal coup, the king announced the launch of the despotic Panchayat rule. The ambitious king wanted to rule the nation as an absolute monarch. He and his aides were not satisfied with the election results. He was in a state of hesitation for several weeks before asking NC parliamentary party leader Koirala to form a government. It clearly hinted at the king's unwillingness to consolidate democracy. Since the beginning, he has intended to prove in one way or another that democracy is not suitable for Nepal.

People-centric steps

The first elected government was gaining ground because of its people-centric steps. It did its bit for the welfare of the common people. Thus, the government was able to win the hearts and minds of the general public with its numerous landmark initiatives, including the land reform measures. But such popular activities deeply hurt the landed aristocrats. That section had long dominated the army. That feudal group must have instigated the king to terminate democracy.

Koirala, a visionary leader, had a different perspective on development. His idea was that guarantees of individual liberty and civil and political rights alone were inadequate for a poor nation like Nepal to move on the path of economic transformation and social development. According to him, democratic socialism was the solution to the nation's problem of underdevelopment.

It is worth mentioning that Koirala was also able to boost Nepal's international image when he delivered his influential statement at a meeting of the United Nations. He was also successful in enhancing Nepal's relations with neighbouring countries. Thanks to Koirala's charismatic leadership and diplomatic acumen, the longstanding border disputes between Nepal and China were settled.

The royal coup plunged Nepal into another dark phase in the nation's political history. However, the nation had to go through a difficult period for three long decades. The people were denied freedom and many democratic rights once again. Although the Panchayat rule had put a ban on political parties, the latter continued to stand out against the autocratic rule. A lot of democracy aspirants had to sacrifice their lives in their bid to restore democracy in the country, while numerous others faced physical and mental torture.

But the oppressive Panchayat rule collapsed with the intensification of the people's movement in 1990. And multiparty democracy was reinstated in the country, generating a lot of hope and optimism among the people. A democratic constitution coupled with the provision of constitutional monarchy was introduced, paving the way for democracy to be institutionalized. The NC was voted to power again.

The initial years were good in terms of political stability and economic growth. But unfortunately, the intra-party feuds within the NC started growing precariously. Many lawmakers elected on a Nepali Congress ticket strongly opposed the then prime minister, Girija Prasad Koirala, even in parliament. Then, Koirala dissolved the House and announced a snap poll. The step was reviewed by the Supreme Court. The judiciary, however, ruled in favour of dissolution. Then, the nation went to elections. A hung parliament was formed. With that poll outcome, political instability began in the nation.

In the 1999 elections as well, the NC was given a majority. Its leader, Krishna Prasad Bhattarai, became the prime minister. But the'saint' leader Bhattarai could not remain in power for long due to infighting within the party. At that time, the Maoist insurgency was escalating. With the Royal Palace Massacre in June 2001, the country passed through a worsening political scenario. Taking advantage of that situation, King Gyanendra declared a state of emergency, dissolved the parliament, and suspended major constitutional rights in February 2005. He grabbed all the executive power for himself. Thus, Gyanendra seemed to have followed in his father Mahendra's footprints. But his misstep ultimately led to his downfall. Seven political parties, including the NC and CPN-UML, reached an understanding to join hands with the erstwhile CPN-Maoists to end the monarchy once and for all and reestablish democracy in the country.

As per their agreement, the parties staged nationwide protests against the monarchy. In 2006, Gyanendra agreed to give democracy back to the people. The parties proceeded with their plan to draft an inclusive democratic constitution through the Constituent Assembly (CA). In 2008, the first CA election was held. But the CA failed to carry out the responsibility entrusted to it. In 2013, the second CA polls were held. And it wrote the constitution that was promulgated in September 2015.

However, even after the introduction of the new national charter, the nation has failed to address a myriad of national issues and challenges. One of the main factors behind this is that the political parties and their leaders have focused their attention only on acquiring power. They appear to have failed to raise themselves above their trivial partisan and personal interests. This has really become a matter of great concern.

The federal Republican system has yet to be institutionalised, although the new constitution has been in effect for several years. Many of the laws that are required to implement the constitution are yet to be enacted. Political anomalies are widespread. Political parties are often found infringing upon the constitution. In addition, the national economy is still in the doldrums. The problem of unemployment seems to have been exacerbated, forcing hundreds of thousands of youths to leave the country for a job opportunity and higher education. What is more saddening is that the nation's public debt has been rising alarmingly.

Corruption control

The rampant corruption in the country has hampered the process of overall development. The situation appears to have worsened with the increased involvement of politicians in corruption. This tendency has created a sense of distaste among the people. While the government has stepped up some measures to check corruption, its attempts alone will not be sufficient to control this scourge.

What is also lacking is a good political culture in the country. As we celebrate National Democracy Day, all political parties must express their sincere commitment to embracing democratic values and act accordingly. Otherwise, their lip services alone will not make any difference to the lives and livelihoods of the common people. They must stand united when it comes to the task of nation-building. Forging political consensus is a must before taking major decisions and rectifying mistakes made in the past. As everyone has different intelligences, the nation must go for meritocracy in order to make progress.

(The author is former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

Women's Contribution To Democratic Upheavals



Babita Basnet



While discussing women's participation in nation-building and the democratic process in Nepal, it is necessary to recognise their historic role in the Nalapani War. Serving as warriors in the battle of Nalapani in Dehradun (currently located in Northern India) in 1815, Nepali women fought alongside their male counterparts in a heroic resistance against the British army. Despite facing adversaries with the better equipped, trained, and outnumbered British army, women courageously stood their ground, contributing to the defence of their homeland.

This historical event underscored their pivotal role in shaping the nation's history and identity. There exists a profound link between democracy and the women's movement in Nepal. Women have actively advocated for democracy, while democracy, in turn, has supported the movement from a rights-based perspective. Nepal's women's movement dates back to 1942 with the Yogmaya revolution. Yogmaya was imprisoned for her demand of "Dharma Rajya" (nation with justice) under the Rana rulers. She, along with more than 60 other women, jumped into the Arun River, demanding women's freedom and social reform in the country. It was a symbolic protest against the despotic Rana rule.

Women's struggle for equal participation in the key organs of the state, crucial decision-making processes, and a life of dignity and happiness goes on.

Organised movement

The first women's organisation, Nepal Mahila Sangh (Nepal Women Association), was established under the leadership of Mangaladevi Singh in 1948, marking a turning point in the emancipation of Nepali women reeling from social, political, economic, and cultural discrimination. Other notable women activists, such as Sahana Pradhan and Snehalata, also joined the association. Its primary objective was to secure voting rights for women, which were eventually granted in 1954. Notably, Sahana Pradhan made history in 1954 by becoming the country's first elected woman representative, serving as the ward president of Ward No. 8 in Kathmandu. Despite her absence from active politics later, her husband, Manamohan Adhikari, became the Prime Minister in 1994.

In 1990, women played a significant role in the democratic movement that ended the 30-year rule of the party-less Panchayat, ushering in multi-party democracy with constitutional monarchy. Women from various backgrounds, including those from prominent political families and rural communities, actively participated in these movements.

Quota and participation

Under the new democratic set-up, women's socio-economic status was elevated. Several female politicians held ministerial and other important positions, shaping the political and administrative landscape of the country. The 1990 Constitution introduced a groundbreaking provision—a 5 per cent reservation for women—that aimed to enhance women's participation in politics. Initially intended for women who faced challenges competing with men in politics, this reservation system eventually increased their participation. Even seasoned politicians like Sahana Pradhan and Shailaja Acharya received electoral tickets within this 5 per cent quota. Ever since, it has been a gradual evolutionary process that has finally reached the point of committing to a 33 per cent quota for women in parliament.

The 1990 political change also enhanced the growth of the private sector, non-governmental organisations, rights groups, and other civic associations. Women's involvement in various state mechanisms notably surged, bolstering their entry into the vital organs of the state. A plethora of non-governmental organisations emerged, many dedicated to advancing women's rights and equality. Women's representation in the media sector also grew dramatically, boosting them to fight for structural changes in society. Additionally, the issue of women's inheritance rights was prominently raised.

The ten-year Maoist insurgency (1996–2006) had a significant impact on the country, diverting the development budget towards security and preventing local elections for over two decades. This period created a substantial leadership gap across all sectors, particularly in politics. Despite the disruption, it was a crucial time for women's empowerment. The participation of women as combatants in the Maoist armed movement challenged traditional gender norms, showcasing that women could also wield weapons. In 2005 (B.S. 2062), the Royal Nepali Army amended its recruitment policy to allow women to compete freely in combat roles, whereas previously, they were restricted to technical positions. In conflict situations, while men often joined the war or fled, women took on diverse responsibilities, from household chores to agricultural work and even handling corpses, a shift from traditional gender roles where such tasks were primarily assigned to men.

Following the political upheaval of 2006 (2063 B.S.), Nepal underwent a significant transformation. The CPN-Maoist joined peaceful politics and emerged as the largest political force in the first Constituent Assembly in 2008. The interim constitution prominently highlighted gender equality, stressing the imperative of women's involvement across all tiers of government. In accordance with this principle, the Constituent Assembly Election Act 2063 stipulated a minimum 33 per cent representation for women in the CA. This provision aimed to guarantee the participation of women in political decision-making processes.

Equal citizenship status

The House of Representatives, which was restored following the 2006 people's uprising, declared a provision to ensure 33 per cent female participation in all state structures on May 30, 2006 (Jestha 16, 2063). Lawmaker Bidyadevi Bhandari spearheaded the parliamentary motion, which was seconded by MPs Kamaladevi Pant and Narayan Prakash Saund (NP Saud). The proposal, registered as a matter of urgent public importance in the Parliament Secretariat, emphasised several key objectives. These included ensuring that children could acquire citizenship under either the mother's or father's name, aligning with the goal of promoting equal participation.

Additionally, it sought to guarantee the representation of at least one-third of women in all state structures and called for the repeal of all discriminatory laws.

It underscored the necessity of ending violence against women and aimed to achieve equal citizenship status for women.

The rationale for the discussion was explicitly stated as the imperative to secure equal status for women as citizens. Based on this motion, the Constituent Assembly Election Act guaranteed 33 per cent female participation in both constituent assembly elections. The essence of this commitment is echoed in the 2015 Constitution of Nepal, leading to the formulation of relevant laws or ongoing legislative processes. These are no small feats, but women's struggle for equal participation in the key organs of the state, crucial decision-making processes, and a life of dignity and happiness goes on.

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Impacts Of Social Media In Democracy



Kishor Basyal



Democracy is the system of government that, among other things, aims to create an egalitarian society where every citizen enjoys equal rights and opportunities regardless of his or her social status, faith, race, age, gender, and other differences. This means no one is discriminated against, making them feel the presence of justice and the absence of injustice. In a democracy, people occupy the central stage, not the rulers. And people's participation in it determines how robust it is. The greater their participation, the stronger it is.

Democracy in Nepal was achieved through the untold sacrifices of martyrs and several democratic movements. Today, we are fortunate enough to live in a world where the aspirations of democracy have never been easier to fulfil. This article seeks to discuss how this arguably best form of governance is faring in an era dominated by internet-powered tools like social media, such as Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, etc., and now artificial intelligence (AI).

While social media has the potential to enhance democracy, its effects are complex and multifaceted, requiring careful consideration and regulation.

Voice of voiceless

The rise of social media has empowered people to make themselves heard and to voice their concerns, rages, grievances, or opinions, enabling them to have a say in every decision, whether made by the government or otherwise, that affects them. No other medium has given such a powerful voice to the voiceless before. A sense of social inclusion is also formed as a wide variety of viewpoints and ideas get their due place, boosting social cohesion. As they have allowed citizens to follow a person or a party who echos or represents their grudges, those on the fringe have now found themselves in the mainstream. This is no small achievement.

What's more, because they allow people to communicate seamlessly, they have created and powered influential social organisations working to improve the lives and livelihoods of the less privileged and marginalised. With billions of people now connected to social networks, they have emerged to be a formidable cultural and political force potent enough to alter the course of global events. Vibrant public discussions have galvanised governments to take decisive action or to retract their decisions in the face of backlash.

Its ability to influence public opinion, political discourse, and electoral processes is unparalleled, providing a platform for citizens to engage in political discussions, share information, and rally for social and political causes. Its immense power became evident with the election of Donald Trump as the president of the United States in 2016. Many, including the former US president himself, who extensively leveraged Twitter to win over people, have made it clear that social media played a determining role in the election. In its wake, a flurry of headlines that Russia interfered in the election to propel Trump to the presidency dominated the US mainstream media.



E-government, which heavily uses social media for governance, enables more efficient management processes. Its aim is both the efficient running of government and the promotion of transparency. This is achieved by the digitalisation of services and processes and the increased use and publication of government data. When more data is readily available for use, there is more accountability. These days, we see people filling out their taxes online, registering their vehicles or property online, and making payments online, among many other day-to-day activities. The goal is that as more services get digitalised, the demand for a digitalised government grows, leading to hassle-free and efficient governance.

Yet, social media has also been tapped to undermine democracy. They have been harnessed to spread misinformation, polarisation, and echo chambers, which has eroded trust in democratic values and institutions in some places. Additionally, they have been used for political manipulation, propaganda, and election interference, raising concerns about the integrity of democratic processes. Elections are one of the pillars of a vibrant democracy. In much of the world, periodic, free, and fair elections are indispensable to running a country. The smooth handing over of power by the outgoing government to the democratically elected incoming government forms the basis of stability. Many times, reluctance to transfer power peacefully has meant destablising violence.

The threats have been compounded with the dawn of AI, which can analyse vast amounts of data to identify specific demographics and tailor political advertisements to target them to influence their votes. AI-powered bots and algorithms can spread misinformation or manipulate social media discussions to sway public opinion in favour of a particular candidate or ideology. AI can analyse historical voting patterns and other data to make predictions about election outcomes, which can influence voter turnout.

In some cases, AI algorithms may be used to identify and target certain groups of voters for suppression tactics, such as spreading false information about polling locations or voting procedures, mounting cyberattacks to manipulate voting machines. This has posed a grave risk to the fairness of democratic practices. That said, it has also come as a boon. Using it, we can enhance voter engagement and detect and prevent election fraud. With AI, the world is now equipped with a powerful tool capable of detecting and preventing election fraud. There is also a growing consensus among experts that AI is a force for good if used judiciously. Overall, while social media has the potential to enhance democracy, its effects are complex and multifaceted, requiring careful consideration and regulation.

Delivery

But, despite its merits, a democracy that fails to deliver can be a source of discontent among the masses. There are several countries in sub-Saharan Africa, for example, where non-functional democracies have given way to dictatorships, and that too without much opposition. Fed up with the lacklustre performance, anti-democratic forces are raising their ugly heads time and again. Forget the global south, even in Europe, which has played a pivotal role in the development and spread of democratic principles globally; populism has been on the rise, leading to the erosion of democratic traditions and norms. Reason? Disillusionment with the mainstream parties for failing to live up to the people's expectations. So, making democracy deliver is essential if we want to keep it vibrant.

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